NOIS3 Challenge Playbook

How FedTech PMs lead a NOIS3 challenge from award to closeout. It covers the fifteen workflows in every challenge, the steps in each, and where the client gives input or must approve.

CHALLENGE	**[Challenge name]**
TASK ORDER	**[NOIS3-XXX]**
CLIENT REVIEWER	**[COR name / agency]**
REVIEW WINDOW	**[X] business days per gate**

How PMs use this playbook

A NOIS3 task order is won on a proposal and delivered through fifteen repeatable workflows. As PM, you own all fifteen: the schedule, the client relationship and every approval gate. This playbook gives you the same map for every challenge, so nothing depends on memory and nothing reaches solvers without the right sign-off.

Share it with your outreach, operations and review leads, and with marketing, so every team works from the same steps. Each workflow opens with a section page of best practices, followed by its full step-by-step sheet.

1 · SCOPE

Start with the RFTP

Mark which workflows the SOW calls for. Strike the rest, and add any new one from the blank template.

2 · PLAN

Set the gates at kickoff

Agree the ground rules with the COR and the challenge glossary with the client. Name a reviewer and review window for every orange gate, then build the schedule backward from public dates using the timeline and dependencies page.

3 · RUN

Walk each sheet with the team

Before a workflow starts, review its sheet with the leads. Request blue inputs early, and hold work at each orange gate until sign-off. Run the readiness checks and risk review at each milestone.

4 · CLOSE

Report against the gates

Use the gate list below in monthly and stage-close reports. At closeout, hand the network and records to the agency.

How to read a workflow sheet

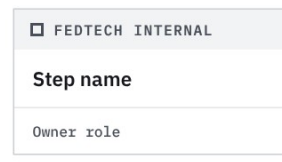
Steps run left to right and step down as the work moves forward. Each card's header band shows who controls that step.

Approval gate

Work stops until the client signs off. The card names the deliverable being approved, so nobody signs off on something vague.

Client input

The step needs information, assets or a decision from the client. It doesn't need a formal sign-off. Ask early so the step doesn't stall.



FedTech internal

Our team owns this step from start to finish. The client sees the result at the next approval gate.

Every approval gate, by workflow

DESIGN & LAUNCH			
01	**Challenge design session**	2 gates · 2 input	Challenge glossary → Challenge design document (allow for agency clearance)
02	**Website build**	4 gates · 2 input	Sitemap → Copy & official rules → Visual design → Go-live
03	**Application platform**	2 gates · 1 input	Application form & eligibility questions → Platform go-live
04	**Challenge.gov listing**	2 gates · 2 input	Listing content → Stage & winner updates
05	**Outreach & recruitment**	2 gates · 2 input	Outreach plan & KPIs → Messaging & content kit
06	**Info session build**	4 gates · 2 input	Agenda & speakers → Promotion copy → Slide deck → Recording & written Q&A
RUN THE COMPETITION			
07	**Competitor management**	3 gates · 2 input	Inbox & escalation rules → FAQ updates → Dispute resolutions
08	**Technical webinar**	3 gates · 1 input	Presenter lineup → Technical content → Written Q&A
09	**Judging & technical review**	2 gates · 2 input	Rubric & weights → Award decisions by federal judges
RESULTS, CLOSEOUT & QUALITY CHECK			
10	**Prize purse distribution**	3 gates · 1 input	Prize structure & payer → Prize terms in the rules → Final payee list
11	**Winner announcement**	1 gate · 1 input	Announcement content, cleared by agency public affairs
12	**In-person convening**	4 gates · 2 input	Venue & date → Agenda & speakers → Event materials → Recap content
13	**Reporting & closeout**	4 gates · 2 input	Project plan → Monthly reports → Stage-close reports → Final report
14	**Subcontractor management**	2 gates · 0 input	Named subcontractor at award → Any change to a sub, its scope or key staff
15	**Pipeline & outreach QA**	1 gate · 2 input	Ecosystem assumptions & pipeline targets (checks Workflow 05)

+ Add a workflow — Duplicate the blank template sheet for any workflow a task order adds.

Ground rules for client review

1. **Every gate has a named client reviewer and a fixed review window.** Both are set at kickoff and put in the schedule.
2. **One consolidated feedback round per gate.** A second round covers only changes we introduced while addressing the first.
3. **Nothing solver-facing goes public without its gate.** That includes site pages, Challenge.gov, promotions, decks, recordings and written answers.
4. **Anything said live is published in writing to every solver.** No team gains an advantage by attending a session.
5. **Section 508 accessibility is checked before anything goes public,** not fixed after launch.
6. **Rules, rubrics and platform are client-approved at least [30] days before each stage opens.** Confirm the exact lead time against each task order.
7. **Federal judges make every award decision.** FedTech, partners and SMEs advise and score; they never pick winners.
8. **CoECI and the backup CoECI contact are on every client communication.** Copied on every email and invited, at least as optional, to every meeting.

VERSION	**[v1.X]**	OWNER	**[Name, FedTech]**
UPDATED	**[Date]**	CHANGES	**Log lessons after each challenge's after-action review**

Based on the NOIS3-073 proposal and CoECI's stated expectations. Every task order's RFTP and SOW differ, so check each sheet against the current one and add or remove workflows to match.

Contents

Start with the general guidance pages, then use each workflow's section page and step sheet as the work begins. Page numbers match the PDF.

START HERE

01	**Playbook overview**	
02	**Contents**	
03	**The FedTech way: principles**	
04	**The FedTech way: design method**	
05	**Where CoECI sits**	
06	**Participant and client journeys**	
07	**Timeline and dependencies**	
08	**Milestone readiness checks**	
09	**Risks and early warnings**	

ANNEX AND REFERENCES

48	Templates	ANNEX
49	Design document key questions, 1 of 2	ANNEX
50	Design document key questions, 2 of 2	ANNEX
51	Evaluation rubric template	ANNEX
52	Blank workflow template	ANNEX
53	References	
54	References, continued	

DESIGN & LAUNCH · 01–06

10	**Challenge design session**	SECTION
11	Challenge design session	SHEET
12	Challenge glossary	SHEET
13	Challenge design document	SHEET
14	Rules and compliance	SHEET
15	**Website build**	SECTION
16	Website build	SHEET
17	**Application platform**	SECTION
18	Application management platform	SHEET
19	**Challenge.gov listing**	SECTION
20	Challenge.gov listing	SHEET
21	**Outreach & recruitment**	SECTION
22	Outreach & recruitment	SHEET
23	**Info session**	SECTION
24	Info session build	SHEET

RUN THE COMPETITION · 07–09

25	**Competitor management**	SECTION
26	Competitor management	SHEET
27	**Technical webinar**	SECTION
28	Technical webinar	SHEET
29	**Judging & technical review**	SECTION
30	Judging & technical review	SHEET
31	Developing the evaluation rubric	SHEET
32	Evaluation benchmarks	SHEET

QUALITY CHECK · 15

44	**Pipeline & outreach quality check**	SECTION
45	Pipeline & outreach quality check	SHEET
46	Ecosystem map and pipeline assumptions	SHEET
47	Outreach plan and partner QA	SHEET

RESULTS & CLOSEOUT · 10–14

33	**Prize purse distribution**	SECTION
34	Worked example: NOIS3-085	SHEET
35	Prize purse distribution	SHEET
36	**Winner announcement**	SECTION
37	Winner announcement	SHEET
38	**In-person convening**	SECTION
39	In-person convening	SHEET
40	**Reporting & closeout**	SECTION
41	Reporting & closeout	SHEET
42	**Subcontractor management**	SECTION
43	Subcontractor management	SHEET

THE FEDTECH WAY · PRINCIPLES DRAFT FOR REVIEW

How FedTech designs a challenge

Six principles behind every NOIS3 challenge we design. They explain why the workflows in this playbook are built the way they are, and they are what makes a FedTech challenge different from an administered competition.

01

Design for what happens after the prize

A challenge is a means, not the product. We design for the solutions, partnerships and capability that outlast it.

IN PRACTICE

Agree with the client what success looks like a year after the award, and design backward from it.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

Qu-SAFE is framed as a durable cross-domain network NCATS and BPS keep using, not an administered event.

02

Find the real barrier

The obvious problem is rarely the one stopping progress. We name the barrier the challenge must actually remove.

IN PRACTICE

Ask what already works, what does not exist yet, and why nobody has bridged the gap.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

Quantum biosensing already works in the lab; the missing piece is the bridge to preclinical toxicology.

03

Know both sides of the gap

We work where invention meets adoption, so we design for the people who build solutions and the people who must use them.

IN PRACTICE

Map solvers and adopters together; invite adopters in early, not only at the award.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

The convening is built for translation, with SBIR/STTR staff, investors and adopters, not for ceremony.

04

Recruit people, not audiences

The right ten teams matter more than a thousand sign-ups. We recruit from a named list and help teams form.

IN PRACTICE

Build a named target list, and treat matchmaking as a product when no single field can solve it alone.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

Office hours, a partner board and mixers pair physicists with toxicologists; Stage 1 is a team-formation tool.

05

Build the review around the problem

Judging must be able to tell a real advance from a confident claim. We assemble reviewers who can, and surface disagreement instead of averaging it away.

IN PRACTICE

Match reviewer expertise to every criterion; reconcile divergent scores before federal judges decide.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

Two review tracks, quantum hardware and toxicology, score independently, then reconcile.

06

Leave the government something it keeps

Networks, methods and data are handed over, not held. We make tradeoffs visible so the client chooses with eyes open.

IN PRACTICE

Plan the handoff from kickoff; present options with costs whenever scope, budget or schedule is tight.

EXAMPLE · QU-SAFE (NOIS3-073)

The SME roster and stakeholder network go to NCATS and BPS at closeout; the alternate approach shows the cost of a deeper bench.

THE FEDTECH WAY · DESIGN METHOD DRAFT FOR REVIEW

Frame, map, structure, judge, connect, transfer

Six steps that turn an RFTP into a challenge built for its outcome. Steps 1 to 4 happen in the design session and fill the challenge design document; steps 5 and 6 run through delivery and closeout.

STEP 1 Frame

Find the real barrier and agree what success looks like after the award.

ASK

- What already works, and what is missing?
- Why has nobody closed this gap?
- What will the agency do with the results?

PRODUCES

Problem statement · goals and success measures

WF 01

COMMON TRAP

Restating the RFTP as the problem.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

The barrier is the bridge to toxicology, not the physics.

STEP 2 Map

Map who can solve it and who must adopt it.

ASK

- Which communities hold the skills?
- Who would use a winning solution?
- Which teams must we reach by name?

PRODUCES

Named target list · adopter map

WF 05 · 15

COMMON TRAP

An open call with no named targets.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

Quantum, toxicology and translation channels, listed by name.

STEP 3 Structure

Choose stages and incentives that serve the outcome, not the calendar.

ASK

- What does each stage need to produce?
- What helps teams form and improve?
- Which non-cash incentives matter here?

PRODUCES

Stage structure · prize structure · eligibility

WF 01 · 03 · 10

COMMON TRAP

Stages set by the calendar, not by what teams can produce.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

Stage 1 is optional and works as a team-formation tool.

STEP 4 Judge

Design evaluation that can tell a real advance from a confident claim.

ASK

- Who can credibly judge each criterion?
- Where will reviewers disagree, and why?
- What evidence must teams show?

PRODUCES

Criteria and weights · review architecture

WF 09

COMMON TRAP

One generic panel for a problem that spans fields.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

Two review tracks scoring independently, then reconciled.

STEP 5 Connect

Run the challenge as a network: matchmaking, events and a convening built for translation.

ASK

- Who needs to meet whom?
- Which adopters and funders should be in the room?
- How do teams keep in touch afterward?

PRODUCES

Matchmaking plan · info session · webinar · convening

WF 05 · 06 · 08 · 12

COMMON TRAP

A convening that is only an awards ceremony.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

Mixers per stage; convening with SBIR/STTR staff and investors.

STEP 6 Transfer

Hand the government what it keeps, and follow the winners.

ASK

- What does the agency keep at closeout?
- Who follows the winners at 6 and 12 months?
- What did we learn for the next challenge?

PRODUCES

Handoff package · follow-up plan · after-action review

WF 13

COMMON TRAP

Planning the handoff in the last month.

QU-SAFE EXAMPLE

SME roster and network handed to NCATS and BPS.

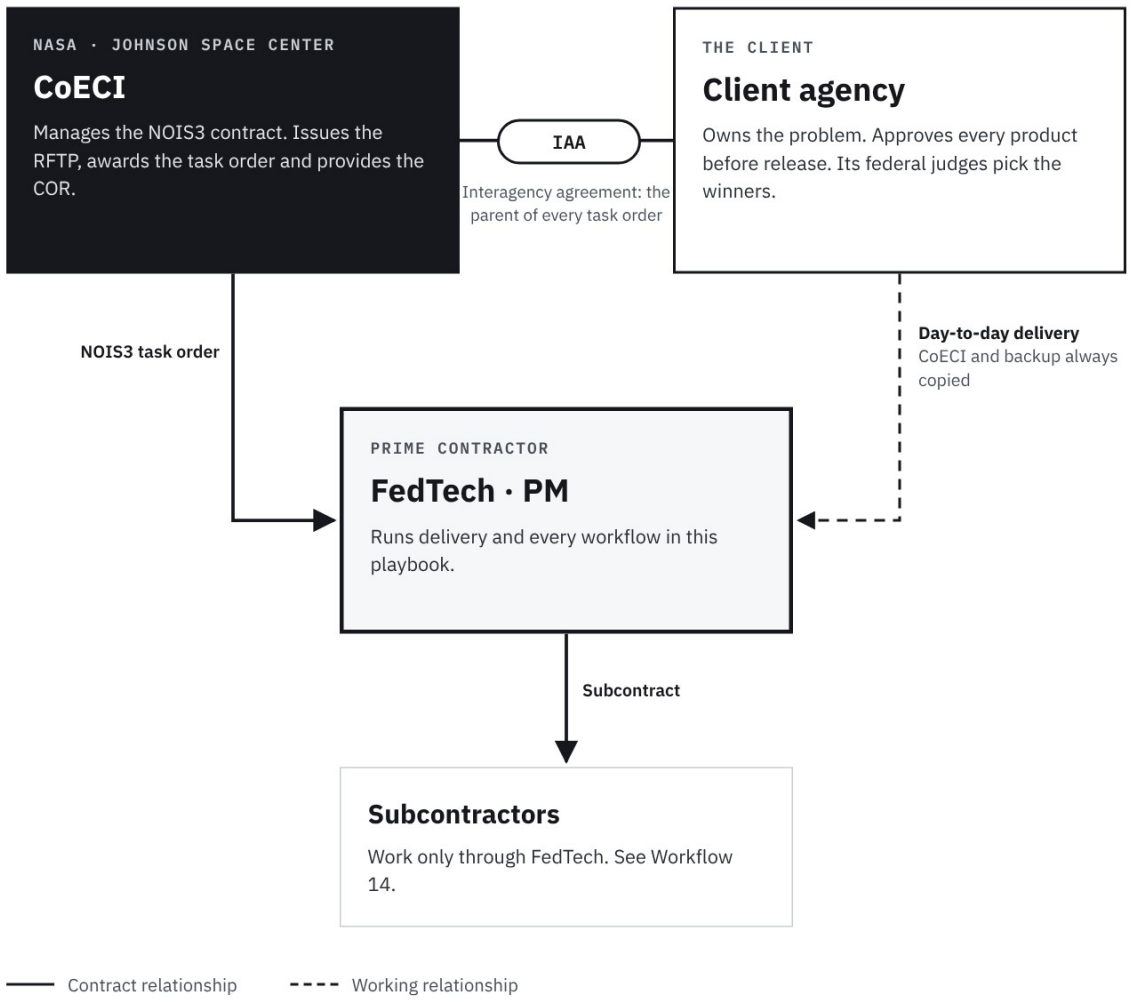
DESIGN SESSION · FILLS THE DESIGN DOCUMENT (WF 01)

DELIVERY AND CLOSEOUT

BEFORE YOU START · THE CONTRACT BEHIND EVERY TASK ORDER

Where CoECI sits

NASA's Center of Excellence for Collaborative Innovation (CoECI), at Johnson Space Center, manages the NOIS3 contract. Every task order flows from an interagency agreement between CoECI and the client agency. That makes CoECI a material party to the work, even when it stays out of day-to-day delivery.



Rules for every PM

1. **Copy CoECI and the backup CoECI contact on every client communication.** Every email, and every meeting invite, at least as optional.
2. **Never sidestep CoECI, knowingly or not.** Above all on how the contract applies: scope, schedule, deliverables, acceptance and price.
3. **Treat CoECI as a material party to the task order.** It stays out of delivery when things go well. That is not the same as being out of the loop.
4. **Know the chain.** The interagency agreement between CoECI and the client agency is the parent. Our task order flows from it.
5. **CoECI's COR oversees the task order; the client agency approves the products.** Settle contract questions with the COR in writing, and route product approvals through the client agency.

CoECI's six expectations

How CoECI expects FedTech to run every project, challenge or not.

01
Agenda 24 hours ahead
Before every call and every review touchpoint, recurring or not.

02
Notes within one business day
Every action item carries a name and a date.

03
Open with the schedule
Where we are and what's next. Two minutes that prevent drift.

04
Box links that don't expire
NASA defaults links to expire. Whoever sends a link turns expiry off, every time.

05
Name every owner
Each next step and each approval leaves the call with a named owner.

06
Book meetings live
Schedule follow-ups on the call itself, not over email.

When documents disagree, the signed schedule governs unless the client agrees otherwise in writing. Raise the conflict with the COR early, CoECI copied, rather than letting it drift. CoECI is open to practices we bring back.

THE CHALLENGE JOURNEY

Two journeys, one challenge

Solvers and the client move through the same challenge at the same time, wanting different things. The PM lane shows how we serve both. Where the solver and client lanes meet, our work is most visible.

- Participant (solver) journey
- Client (agency) journey
- FedTech PM focus
- Shared moment — Both lanes meet

	1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH			2 · RUN THE COMPETITION			3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT		
	01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08	09
LANE 1 — Participant What the solver does, and what they need from us	**Discover** Finds the challenge on Challenge.gov, through outreach or a partner post. **Needs:** a fast answer to "is this for me?"	**Learn** Reads the rules and FAQ, and joins the info session. **Needs:** plain answers, the same for everyone	**Register & team up** Registers and finds partners through matchmaking. **Needs:** easy sign-up and a way to meet collaborators	**Build** Develops the solution, asks questions and joins the technical webinar. **Needs:** fast, consistent answers	**Submit** Uploads the submission before the deadline. **Needs:** a reliable platform and reminders	**Wait for review** Waits while reviewers score and judges decide. **Needs:** a clear timeline and no surprises	**Hear results** Hears privately first, then sees the public announcement. **Needs:** timely, respectful notice, win or lose	**Showcase** Presents at the convening and meets funders and adopters. **Needs:** coaching and real introductions	**Move forward** Enters the next stage, or answers the post-award survey. **Needs:** a path beyond the prize
		Info session			Technical webinar			Announcement	Convening
LANE 2 — Client What the agency does, and the workflow behind it	**Kick off** Shapes the challenge in the design session and agrees the approval gates. WF 01 · 13	**Approve launch** Signs off the site, official rules and Challenge.gov listing. WF 02 · 03 · 04	**Amplify** Shares through agency channels and speaks at the info session. WF 05 · 06	**Guide** Rules on policy and eligibility questions; clears webinar content. WF 07 · 08	**Set the bar** Approves the rubric and names federal judges. WF 09	**Decide** Federal judges select the winners; prizes are verified and paid. WF 09 · 10	**Announce** Public affairs clears and releases the results. WF 11	**Convene** Leadership meets winners, funders and partners. WF 12	**Close out** Accepts the final report and receives the network handoff. WF 13
LANE 3 — FedTech PM Where you focus at each stage	**Lock scope** Confirm in-scope workflows, ground rules and every gate with the COR.	**Launch** Get the site and Challenge.gov listing through their gates and live.	**Fill the pipeline** Run targeted outreach and matchmaking; track registrations weekly.	**Keep answers equal** Run the inbox, FAQ and webinar so every team gets the same answer.	**Protect the deadline** Keep the platform stable and send reminders; log late issues.	**Run review** Screen conflicts, run scoring and reconciliation, brief the judges.	**Coordinate release** Line up public affairs, winners and channels for one release.	**Produce the event** Deliver the convening and capture every introduction made.	**Report and hand off** Deliver final reports, the survey and the network handoff.

FOR THE PM

Plan for the shared moments.
Info session, webinar, announcement and convening are where solvers and the agency see our work together. Give them the most rehearsal.

Never leave a solver waiting silently.
Steps 05 to 07 feel longest to solvers. Publish the review timeline and keep to it.

Every client step is a gate or an input.
Match each one to its workflow sheet so the agency is never surprised by a request.

GENERAL GUIDANCE · WHEN EACH WORKFLOW STARTS

Timeline and dependencies

Most workflows start well before solvers see them. Use this to plan backward from launch: anchor the milestones to the RFTP's dates, then check each dependency below before you lock the schedule. Phase widths are illustrative, not to scale.

Multi-stage challenges repeat the open, judging and results bands for each stage (Workflows 03 to 11). Reporting adds a stage-close report each time.

Key dependencies

Read "A → B" as: A must be done, or at least decided, before B can finish.

`01 → 02 · 03 · 04 · 05`

Design document cleared

Final rules, site copy, the application form, the listing and launch outreach. Draft them during clearance; publish nothing until it clears.

`01 → everything`

Glossary agreed

Every page, form, deck and FAQ uses the agreed terms. Agree them before anyone writes copy.

`09 · 10 → 01`

Rubric and prize structure

Evaluation criteria and prize terms go into the design document, so start both in design, not after launch.

`02 + 03 + 04 → launch`

Same-day go-live

Site, platform and Challenge.gov listing go live together. Each needs its own client gate first.

`06 → 05 · 04`

Info session date and speakers

Lock them before promotion names them; outreach and the listing announce the date.

`09 → close`

Judges recruited and screened

Recruit and conflict-screen during the open period so scoring starts the day submissions close.

`09 → 10 → 11`

Decision, verification, announcement

Federal judging decides; verify winners and payees; notify privately; then announce publicly and update Challenge.gov.

`15 → 05 → launch`

Pipeline targets agreed

The ecosystem assumptions and targets set outreach KPIs; marketing's plan passes QA before it goes to the client.

Milestone readiness checks

Use this at each milestone on the timeline page. If an item is open, either close it or write down who accepted the risk and why before moving on. Review it on the status call the week before each milestone.

☐ PM checks it off
☐ Needs a client gate or client decision

▼ KICKOFF

Ready to start

- ☐ RFTP, SOW and proposal read; workflows struck or added
- ☐ CoECI and backup CoECI on every client distribution list
- ☐ Clearance path and time asked for and written down
- ☐ Subcontractors approved and onboarded
- ☐ Status call cadence and report dates agreed
- ☐ Baseline schedule built back from public dates

▼ DESIGN CLEARED

Ready to build

- ☐ Design document cleared, versioned and dated
- ☐ Glossary agreed and shared with every lead
- ☐ Goals and success measures agreed
- ☐ Prize structure and payer decided
- ☐ Evaluation criteria outline agreed
- ☐ Rules and compliance checklist answered
- ☐ Ecosystem map and pipeline targets agreed

▼ LAUNCH

Ready to go public

- ☐ Site, platform and listing approved
- ☐ Section 508, privacy and load tests passed
- ☐ Inbox, FAQ and escalation rules live
- ☐ Outreach kit approved; target list loaded
- ☐ Info session date and speakers locked
- ☐ Judge recruitment under way
- ☐ Outreach plan and partners passed QA

▼ CLOSE

Ready to judge

- ☐ Judges recruited, conflict-screened, onboarded
- ☐ Deadline-day support and backup path ready
- ☐ Late or failed submissions policy agreed
- ☐ Submission counts reported to client and CoECI
- ☐ Rubric and scoring guide final
- ☐ Stage-close report started
- ☐ Pipeline checked against assumptions

▼ DECISION

Ready to announce

- ☐ Federal judges' decision documented
- ☐ Winner eligibility verified
- ☐ Payee details collected
- ☐ Announcement plan and embargo approved
- ☐ Winners notified privately; consent received
- ☐ Feedback to non-winners drafted

▼ AWARDS PAID

Ready to close

- ☐ Every payment confirmed and reconciled
- ☐ Challenge.gov and site show results
- ☐ Convening held or scheduled
- ☐ Post-award survey cleared to send
- ☐ Winner follow-up plan agreed
- ☐ Open actions listed with owners

▼ END

Done

- ☐ Final report accepted
- ☐ Results measured against design goals
- ☐ After-action review with client and CoECI
- ☐ Records, data and network handed over
- ☐ Subcontracts closed out
- ☐ This playbook updated with lessons

1 **A week before.** Walk the column on the status call. Assign an owner and date to every open item.

2 **At the milestone.** Check off what is done. Review the risks page with the team.

3 **If something is still open.** Hold, or record who accepted the risk and why, and tell the client and CoECI in writing.

Multi-stage challenges run the Launch to Awards paid checks again for each stage.

Milestones match the timeline and dependencies page.

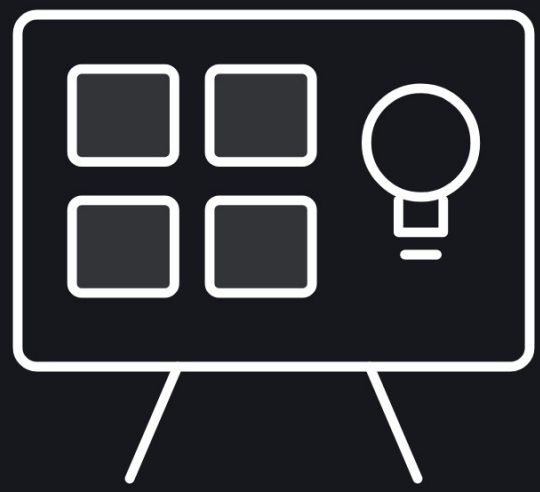
Risks and early warnings

The ten problems that most often hurt a challenge, the signs that show up first, and what to do. Review the list with the team at each milestone and record the owner for any risk you are carrying.

RISK	EARLY WARNING	PREVENT OR RESPOND	WORKFLOW	OWNER / STATUS
01 **Agency clearance runs long**	No clearance path or time named at kickoff; comments arrive from offices nobody listed	Ask at kickoff and write it into the schedule. Draft downstream copy in parallel. Hold a dated buffer before launch.	01	
02 **Low or narrow registration**	Registrations behind plan at the midpoint; one channel produces most sign-ups	Track weekly by channel and shift effort. Ask partners for a second push. Discuss an extension with the client early, not on the last day.	05 · 15	
03 **Too few strong submissions**	Info session questions show the problem is unclear; few teams formed	Tighten the problem statement and FAQ. Use the webinar and matchmaking. Agree in the rules what happens if no entry merits an award.	02 · 08 · 09	
04 **Judge conflict or drop-out**	Late conflict disclosures; judges slow to confirm onboarding	Recruit spares. Screen conflicts before submissions close. Keep a backup panel list approved by the client.	09	
05 **Platform fails near the deadline**	Load test skipped; support tickets climb in the final week	Load test before launch. Staff deadline day. Publish a backup submission path and the rule for late entries.	03 · 07	
06 **Public information disagrees**	Site, Challenge.gov and FAQ answers differ; solvers quote different dates	One source of approved copy. Update every channel the same day. Log each change.	02 · 04 · 07	
07 **Prize payments are late**	Payer not named in the design; payee details missing at decision	Decide the payer during design. Collect payee details during verification. Track every payment to confirmation.	10	
08 **Scope creeps outside the task order**	"Can you also" requests on calls; new deliverables without a written ask	Note it on the call, then route it through CoECI and the COR in writing before any work starts.	CoECI	
09 **CoECI left out of the loop**	A client thread without CoECI or the backup copied	Reply-all with CoECI added and a short recap. Check distribution lists at every milestone.	CoECI	
10 **Winners stall after the award**	No follow-up plan; the agency has no path to test or adopt solutions	Agree success measures and a follow-up plan in the design document. Schedule a 6- or 12-month check-in.	01 · 13	

The agency is not obliged to award a prize if no entry meets the criteria. Agree with the client, in the rules, how that case is handled before launch.

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH



WORKFLOW 01 OF 15

Challenge Design Session

SECTION 01 · BEFORE YOU START

Challenge Design Session

The first workstream after kickoff. FedTech and the client turn the RFTP into an agreed challenge design and an agreed set of terms, before anything is built or published.

Best practices

01 **Design before anything is drafted.** Site copy, rules, the platform and the rubric all build on these decisions.

02 **Send a pre-read 24 hours ahead, CoECI invited.** Agenda, draft problem statement and draft glossary.

03 **Leave with decisions, not ideas.** Problem statement, target solvers, stage structure and how winners are judged.

04 **Agree the words.** Settle the glossary before anyone writes rules or copy; use the agency's terms, not ours.

05 **Start the design document at kickoff.** Agency clearance can take a month; put it on the schedule and publish nothing until it clears.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who must be in the design session to make decisions, not just give input?
- Who clears the design document, in what order, and how long does it take?
- What does success look like a year after the award?

CLIENT GATES 05 Glossary · 06 Challenge design document

Steps, glossary and design document follow →

WORKFLOW 01 OF 15

Challenge Design Session

A working session with the client that turns the RFTP into an agreed challenge design: the problem, the solvers, the stages, how winners are judged and the words we all use. Every other workflow builds on what it decides.

FEDTECH LEAD	PM + Review Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	Client agency + CoECI COR
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks after kickoff
FINAL OUTPUT	Approved challenge design

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

FEDTECH INTERNAL

01

Prepare

- Read the RFTP and SOW against the proposal
- Research the problem and the solver landscape
- Draft problem statement options and a starter glossary
- Agenda out 24 hours ahead, CoECI invited

PM

CLIENT INPUT

02

Discovery pre-read

- Short questionnaire before the session
- Goals, constraints and non-negotiables
- Prior efforts, stakeholders and partners

CLIENT PROVIDES
Goals, constraints, prior work and who must be in the room

PM

CLIENT INPUT

03

Run the design session

- Frame the problem and the gap
- Target solvers and where to find them
- Stages, prizes and what winning looks like
- Walk the glossary term by term

CLIENT PROVIDES
Decisions in the room, not just ideas

PM + Review Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Draft the design document

- Skeleton opened at kickoff, filled here
- Prize structure, timeline, submission requirements
- Evaluation criteria and intellectual property
- Open questions with owners and dates

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

05

Agree the glossary

- One agreed definition per term
- Agency and CoECI language wins over ours
- Shared with every FedTech lead and sub

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
The challenge glossary (next page)

PM — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Approve the design

- One consolidated client and CoECI round
- Agency clearance: up to a month at some agencies
- Version and date the cleared document

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
The cleared challenge design document (sheet after the glossary)

PM — Clearance: [X] weeks

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Hand off to the workstreams

- Brief every lead on the approved design
- Feeds site copy, platform, outreach, rubric and prizes
- Any later change comes back here first

PM

GATE SEQUENCE

05 · Glossary
Agree the words before anyone writes rules or copy

06 · Design document
Cleared by the agency; the reference for every scope question

Runs first, right after kickoff

Feeds Workflows 02 to 10

Terms to agree with the client

Agencies, CoECI and FedTech often use the same word for different things. Agree each term at the design session, fill in the last column, and use only the agreed words in the rules, site, platform, Challenge.gov and outreach.

TASK ORDER	[NOIS3-XXX]
AGREED ON	[Date]
CLIENT SIGN-OFF	[Name, agency]

TERM	COMMON MEANING	WHY IT NEEDS AGREEMENT	AGREED DEFINITION
Stage / phase / milestone	A period of the competition with its own submissions and winners	RFTPs use all three, sometimes in one document	
Challenge / competition	The whole prize program, or a single stage within it	Sets what the name on the site and Challenge.gov covers	
Solver / participant / team	Who enters: an individual, a team, or an organization	Drives eligibility rules and who gets paid	
Registration / application / submission	Signing up, entering a stage, and the work that gets judged	Each is counted separately in CoECI's reporting	
Eligible	Allowed to enter, and allowed to win a prize	These can differ, and the rules must say which applies when	
Reviewer / SME / judge	Experts who score, and federal officials who decide	Only federal judges make award decisions	
Rubric / evaluation criteria	Published criteria, and the scoring guide reviewers use	Decides what solvers see versus what stays internal	
Winner / finalist / honorable mention	Tiers of recognition, with or without prize money	Sets who is paid, announced and invited onward	
Prize purse / award	The total money for a stage, and each amount paid out	Also settles who pays: FedTech or the agency	
Open / close / deadline	The exact date, time and time zone a stage accepts entries	Disputes start here; name the time zone every time	
Notification / announcement	Private word to a team, versus public release of results	Sets the embargo and what may be said before release	
Deliverable / acceptance	A contract output, and the act that confirms it is complete	RFTPs often set no acceptance terms; agree them in writing	
Client / agency / COR / CoECI	Who owns the problem, who manages the contract, who approves what	Every gate in this playbook depends on it	
[Add a term]			

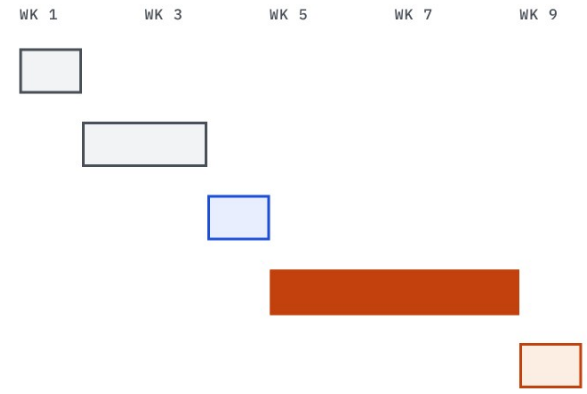
What the design document must settle

The client clears this document before anything public is final. Agency clearance is slow, so open the document at kickoff, fill it at the design session, and put clearance time on the schedule from day one.

TASK ORDER	[NOIS3-XXX]
VERSION / DATE	[v0.X] · [Date]
CLEARANCE PATH	[Agency offices, in order]
CLEARANCE TIME	[X] weeks, confirmed by client

SECTION	WHAT IT MUST SETTLE	FEEDS	STATUS / OWNER
Prize structure CLIENT NAMED	Total purse, prizes per stage, number and size of awards, non-cash prizes, and who pays winners	WF 10 · 03	
Timeline CLIENT NAMED	Open and close dates with time zone, judging windows, announcement and convening dates	WF 02 · 04 · 09 · 11 · 12	
Submission requirements CLIENT NAMED	What solvers submit, format and page limits, required forms, how and where they submit	WF 03 · 07	
Evaluation criteria CLIENT NAMED	Published criteria and weights, the review process, and who makes award decisions	WF 09	
Intellectual property CLIENT NAMED	Who owns submissions, any license to the government, data rights and publicity consent	WF 02 · 09 · 11	
Goals and success measures	Targets for entries, quality and reach, and what happens to winning solutions after the award	WF 05 · 13	
Problem statement	The gap, what a winning solution does, and how the agency will use the results	WF 05 · 06	
Eligibility	Who may enter versus who may win, team rules, and exclusions such as federal employees	WF 02 · 07	
Stage structure	Number of stages, what advances a team, and what each stage produces	WF 03 · 09	
Rules, terms and liability	Legal authority, liability and insurance, conflicts of interest, disqualification (see the compliance sheet)	WF 02 · 04	
Communications and publicity	Announcement plan, embargo, who speaks for the challenge, use of logos	WF 05 · 11	

Build clearance into the schedule



Illustrative weeks. Replace with the client's confirmed clearance time.

WHAT WAITS ON CLEARANCE

Final rules and site copy (WF 02), the application form (WF 03), the Challenge.gov listing (WF 04) and launch outreach (WF 05). Draft them in parallel, but publish nothing until the document clears.

PM CHECKLIST

- Ask at kickoff: who clears it, in what order, and how long it takes
- CoECI and the backup CoECI contact copied on every draft and comment round
- Use the agreed glossary terms throughout
- Changes after clearance may restart clearance; route them through the COR

Example: a CDC/NIOSH client named the first five sections and warned that HHS/CDC/NIOSH clearance could take up to a month. Other agencies differ; confirm with each client.

Questions to settle before the rules are written

FedTech drafts the rules; the agency and its counsel decide them. Answer each question in writing during design, so the design document, site, platform and listing all carry the same terms.

TASK ORDER	**[NOIS3-XXX]**
AGENCY COUNSEL	**[Name, office]**
ANSWERED BY	**[Design cleared]**

Legal authority

WF 01 · 02

Which authority the agency uses: the America COMPETES Act (15 U.S.C. 3719) or its own prize authority. The answers below assume COMPETES; another authority can change them.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Public notice

WF 02 · 04

The notice must cover the subject, rules for entering, how to register, the prize amount and how winners are chosen. Challenge.gov is the usual place.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Eligibility to win

WF 02 · 07 · 10

Under COMPETES, cash winners must register and follow the rules, be a U.S. citizen or permanent resident or a U.S.-based entity, and not be a federal entity or employee acting in that role. Confirm any further limits.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Liability and insurance

WF 02

Whether entrants must carry liability insurance or show financial responsibility, the amounts, and the waiver and indemnity language.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Intellectual property

WF 02 · 09 · 11

The government may not take an interest in an entrant's IP without written consent. Settle any license, data rights and publicity terms in the rules.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Judges

WF 09

Judges must be qualified, fairly balanced and free of family or financial ties to entrants. Agree who may judge, who decides and how conflicts are screened.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Large prizes

WF 10

Big purses can need extra sign-off. Under COMPETES, prizes over $1 million need agency head approval and prizes over $50 million need notice to Congress.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Data, surveys and privacy

WF 03 · 13

What personal data is collected and where it is stored, and whether surveys need Paperwork Reduction Act clearance before they go out.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

Records and reporting

WF 13

How long records are kept, who receives them, and what data the agency needs for its reports on prize competitions.

ANSWER
CONFIRMED BY

A planning aid, not legal advice. Statutory points summarize 15 U.S.C. 3719 as generally applied; the agency's counsel and the task order decide what applies to each challenge.

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH

WORKFLOW 02 OF 15

Website Build

SECTION 02 · BEFORE YOU START

Website Build

The dedicated challenge site is the front door for every solver. It carries the agency's identity, not ours, and handles registration, eligibility screening, submissions and judging. Every later workflow points back to it.

Best practices

01 **Lock the sitemap before anyone writes copy.** Scope creep on a challenge site starts in the page list.

02 **Book agency counsel time at kickoff.** Official rules review is usually the longest gate in the workflow.

03 **Design in agency identity from the first mockup.** Never show contractor branding to the client or to solvers.

04 **Run the Section 508 audit before the staging walkthrough.** The client should review an accessible site, not a list of fixes.

05 **Treat every post-launch rule change as a new gate.** It goes back through copy and rules approval, then to Challenge.gov.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Does the agency require its own domain, template or content system?
- Who approves the copy, and who approves the official rules?
- Who keeps the site running after closeout, and for how long?

CLIENT GATES 02 Sitemap · 03 Copy & rules · 04 Visual design · 07 Go-live

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 02 OF 15

Website Build

The dedicated challenge site carries the agency's identity, not ours. It handles registration, eligibility screening, submissions and judging. It's the first thing solvers see, and every later workflow points back to it.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency comms
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Live, 508-compliant site

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Kickoff & requirements

- Confirm stage structure and public dates from the RFTP
- Collect agency brand guidelines and logo-use rules
- Agree on custom URL and hosting
- Inventory existing content and assets

CLIENT PROVIDES
Brand guidelines, logos, URL preference, key dates

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Sitemap & page plan

- Page list: Home, Challenge, Rules, Prizes, Timeline, FAQ, Resources, Register
- Map registration and submission flows for each stage
- Decide what is public and what sits behind login

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Sitemap, page list and user flows

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Copy & official rules

- Challenge narrative, eligibility, prize and timeline copy
- Official rules: IP, indemnification and liability terms
- Launch FAQ
- Plain-language pass on everything

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All site copy, plus official rules after agency counsel review

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Visual design

- Wireframes for key page templates
- High-fidelity mockups in agency identity, not contractor branding
- Imagery selection and color contrast check

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Homepage and interior page mockups

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Link the application platform

- Add registration and submission entry points to the site
- Match branding and wording between site and platform
- Test the hand-off from site to platform
- Full platform build is Workflow 03

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

QA & Section 508 audit

- Cross-browser and mobile checks
- Section 508 accessibility audit
- Test every form end to end
- Check links, typos and dates against approved copy

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Staging walkthrough & go-live

- Guided walkthrough of the staging site with the client
- One consolidated feedback round, then fixes
- Confirm launch date and announcement timing

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Go-live. Nothing publishes without it.

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

08

Launch & stage updates

- Publish and verify the live site
- Coordinate with the agency's announcement
- Post stage updates and keep the FAQ on a fixed schedule
- Rule changes go back through step 03

CLIENT PROVIDES
Announcement and press timing

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Sitemap
Locks scope before any copy is written

03 · Copy & rules
Needs agency counsel time; schedule it early

04 · Design
Approve mockups, not the built site

07 · Go-live
The final gate before solvers see anything

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH

WORKFLOW 03 OF 15

Application Platform

SECTION 03 · BEFORE YOU START

Application Management Platform

Where solvers register, form teams and submit, and where reviewers score. It holds personal data and every judging record, so it is built, tested and signed off separately from the website.

Best practices

01 **Every question traces to the rules.** If a field doesn't serve eligibility or judging, cut it.

02 **Collect only what you need.** Agree the Privacy Act notice and data retention with the client up front.

03 **Test as an applicant and as a judge.** Run a full submission end to end before go-live, and load-test for deadline day.

04 **Lock the form before the stage opens.** Changing questions mid-stage leaves teams with unequal applications.

05 **Plan the export on day one.** CoECI's post-competition forms need solver and award data in a set shape.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Which platforms does the agency allow, and has ours passed its security and privacy review?
- What does each stage collect, and what personal data do we actually need?
- Who exports and keeps the data at the end?

CLIENT GATES 03 Application form · 06 Platform go-live

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 03 OF 15

Application Management Platform

The system behind the website, where solvers register, form teams and submit, and where reviewers score. It holds personal data and every judging record, so it gets its own workflow and its own sign-off.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	Client agency + CoECI COR
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks, then each stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Live platform, clean data export

2 APPROVAL GATES

1 INPUT POINT

CLIENT INPUT

01

Requirements

- Fields, files and certifications for each stage
- Data retention and Privacy Act needs
- Who needs access, and at what level

CLIENT PROVIDES
Required fields, eligibility questions, data and access rules

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Configure the platform

- Registration and team management
- Eligibility screening questions
- Versioned submissions for each stage
- Agency branding and agreed glossary terms

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Application form

- Every question traces to a rule or a judging criterion
- Privacy Act notice on the form
- Locked before the stage opens

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Application form, eligibility questions and submission requirements

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Reviewer & judge setup

- Load the approved rubric
- Blinded scoring and conflict recusals
- Role-based access for reviewers and judges

Review Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Test: 508, privacy, load

- Section 508 accessibility audit
- Data handling and access checks
- Full test submission, end to end
- Deadline-day load test

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Client test & go-live

- Client walks through as an applicant and as a judge
- One consolidated feedback round
- Go-live timed with the website

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Platform go-live

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Operate during stages

- Monitor registrations and uptime
- Solver help desk, logged like any inquiry
- Deadline extensions only with client approval

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

08

Export & close

- Export submissions, scores and solver data
- Shape it for CoECI's post-competition forms
- Hand records to the agency; close accounts

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

03 · Application form
Locked before the stage opens, never changed mid-stage

06 · Go-live
Launches with the website, not before

Depends on: Workflow 01 design and Workflow 02 site

Feeds judging (Workflow 09) and reporting (Workflow 13)

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH

WORKFLOW 04 OF 15

Challenge.gov Listing

SECTION 04 · BEFORE YOU START

Challenge.gov Listing

The official federal listing for the prize competition. It is usually published through the agency's own Challenge.gov account and points solvers to our site, so it must match the site at every stage.

Best practices

01 **Find the agency's Challenge.gov manager at kickoff.** Publishing usually runs through their account, not ours.

02 **Reuse approved site copy word for word.** Never write new rules language for the listing.

03 **Publish the listing and the site on the same day.** Solvers who find one should never land on a dead link to the other.

04 **Mirror every change on the site.** A date, prize amount or rule that changes on the site changes on Challenge.gov the same day.

05 **Close the loop at the end.** Post winners and close the listing so it never shows an open challenge that has ended.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who holds the agency's Challenge.gov account and publishes the listing?
- How long does the agency's posting review take?
- Who updates the listing at each stage and when winners are named?

CLIENT GATES 04 Listing review · 07 Stage & winner updates

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 04 OF 15

Challenge.gov Listing

The official federal listing for the prize competition. It is usually published through the agency's own Challenge.gov account and points solvers to our challenge site. It must stay in step with the site at every stage.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency Challenge.gov manager
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Live listing, kept current

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Confirm the posting path

- Identify the agency's Challenge.gov manager and account
- Decide: full listing on Challenge.gov, or summary linking to our site
- Confirm the RFTP's posting requirements and dates

CLIENT PROVIDES
Challenge.gov contact, account access process, posting preference

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Draft listing content

- Adapt approved website copy to Challenge.gov's fields
- Summary, prizes, timeline, rules, judging criteria, how to enter
- External link to the challenge site

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Listing assets

- Banner and logo images sized to Challenge.gov specs
- Alt text for every image
- Agency identity only, matching the site

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Client review of listing

- Send a preview of the full listing text and images
- Check that dates, prize amounts and rules match the site word for word
- One consolidated feedback round

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Final listing text and images

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

05

Agency publishes

- Agency manager enters or imports the listing
- Or grants FedTech access, if the agency allows it
- Schedule it to go live with the challenge site

CLIENT PROVIDES
The publish action on the agency account

Ops Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Launch-day check

- Verify the listing is live and every link works
- Cross-check dates and amounts against the site
- Share the listing URL with the outreach team

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Stage & winner updates

- Update the listing when each stage opens and closes
- Post winners once they are announced
- Close the listing at the end of the challenge

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Each update, including the winner posting

Ops Lead Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

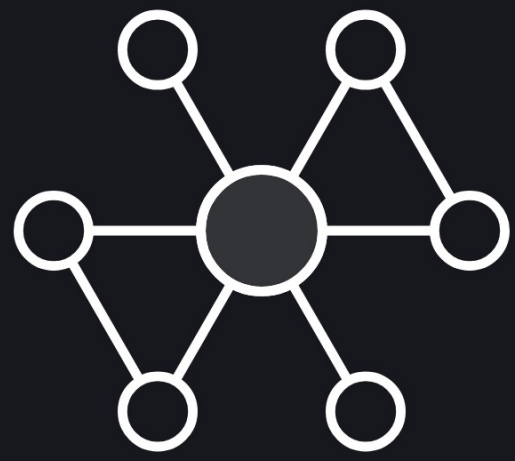
04 · Listing
Reuses approved site copy, so review should be quick

07 · Updates
Every change on the site needs a matching update here

Depends on: Website step 03 (copy & rules approved)

Publishing access varies by agency; confirm at kickoff

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH



WORKFLOW 05 OF 15

Outreach & Recruitment

SECTION 05 · BEFORE YOU START

Outreach & Recruitment

The plan and campaign that bring the right solvers in. The size and quality of the entrant pool is set here, long before judging, and it runs from launch through every stage's close.

Best practices

01 **Recruit from a named target list, not a broadcast.** Know which labs, companies and teams you need before the first send. Workflow 15 checks the list against the ecosystem assumptions.

02 **Approve the content kit once, then reuse it.** One review covers every email, post and partner toolkit that follows.

03 **Treat matchmaking as a product.** A partner board, office hours and mixers turn interested individuals into credible teams.

04 **Measure reach into HBCUs, MSIs and EPSCoR institutions.** Report it monthly as a KPI, not as a promise.

05 **Shift effort weekly toward what converts.** Registrations by channel tell you where the next hour of outreach belongs.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Which solvers must we reach for this to succeed, and where are they?
- Which partners and agency channels will amplify, and who asks them?
- Which registration and reach targets will we report against?

CLIENT GATES 02 Outreach plan & KPIs · 03 Messaging & content kit

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 05 OF 15

Outreach & Recruitment

This is the plan and the campaign that bring the right solvers in. We recruit from a named target list, not a broadcast, and we track participation from underrepresented institutions as a measured result. It runs from launch through each stage's close.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency comms
TYPICAL DURATION	Ongoing, each stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Registrations and teams formed

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Audience research & target list

- Map every solver community the challenge needs
- Build a named list of labs, companies and teams
- Find prior related-challenge participants
- Include HBCUs, MSIs and EPSCoR institutions

CLIENT PROVIDES
Known stakeholders, past participants, agency channels

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Outreach plan

- Goals and KPIs: registrations, submissions, diversity metrics
- Channel plan for each community
- Campaign calendar tied to stage dates
- Matchmaking plan for cross-discipline teams

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Outreach plan and KPI targets

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Messaging & content kit

- Key messages for each audience
- Email templates, social posts and graphics
- Partner toolkit for societies and universities to share
- All drawn from approved site copy

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Messaging, templates and any use of agency name or logo

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

04

Partner & channel engagement

- Brief professional societies and consortia
- Tech-transfer offices and the SBIR/STTR community
- Agency social channels and newsletters

CLIENT PROVIDES
Introductions to partners; posts on agency channels

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Campaign execution

- Direct outreach to the named target list
- Scheduled email and social sends
- Promote the info session and webinars
- Deadline reminders before each stage closes

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Matchmaking & team formation

- Partner-finding board on the challenge site
- Office hours
- Virtual mixers each stage
- Broker introductions across disciplines

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Tracking & adjustment

- Weekly registration and channel metrics
- Shift effort toward channels that convert
- Report KPIs, including diversity metrics, in monthly reports

Outreach Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

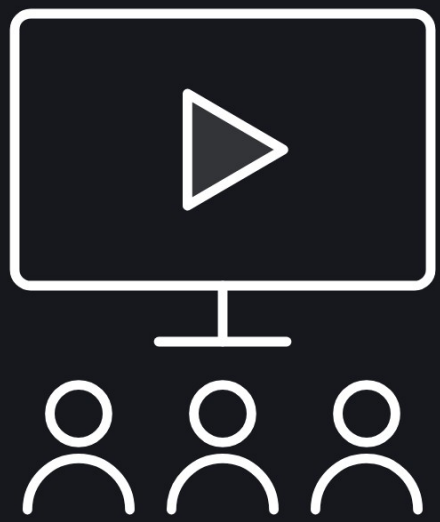
02 · Plan & KPIs
Agree on what success means before spending effort

03 · Content kit
Approve once, then reuse for every send

New messages outside the approved kit go back through step 03

Results feed into the monthly reports (Workflow 13)

PHASE 1 · DESIGN & LAUNCH



WORKFLOW 06 OF 15

Info Session

SECTION 06 · BEFORE YOU START

Info Session

A public live session for prospective solvers: what the challenge is, who can enter, what's at stake and how to apply. It is often the agency's most visible moment after launch, and the first time solvers hear from us directly.

Best practices

01 **Lock the speakers before promotion names them.** A changed speaker after the invite goes out means new copy and a new review.

02 **Build the deck from approved site copy.** Familiar language keeps the client's review short.

03 **Settle policy answers before going live.** Agree the hard eligibility answers with the client in the answer bank, not on air.

04 **Defer anything uncertain to writing.** "We'll answer that for everyone in the FAQ" is always a safe reply.

05 **Publish written answers to every question.** Teams that couldn't attend get the same information as those who did.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who from the agency speaks, and what may they say on record?
- Is the session recorded and posted, and who clears the recording?
- Which hard eligibility questions need answers before we go live?

CLIENT GATES 02 Agenda & speakers · 03 Promotion · 04 Slide deck · 08 Follow-up

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 06 OF 15

Info Session Build

A public, live session for prospective solvers. It covers what the challenge is, who can enter, what's at stake and how to apply. It's often the agency's most visible moment after launch.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency speakers
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Session, recording, written Q&A

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Scope & logistics

- Date, time, length and target audience
- Platform choice (some agencies require their own)
- Registration method
- Live captioning and recording plan

CLIENT PROVIDES
Preferred dates, agency speakers, platform constraints

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Agenda & speakers

- Run of show, minute by minute
- Speaker roles: agency welcome, challenge overview, how to enter, Q&A
- Moderator and backup assigned

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Agenda and speaker lineup

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Promotion

- Registration page on the challenge site
- Email, social and newsletter copy
- Partner and channel outreach list
- Reminder sequence to registrants

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Promotional copy and any use of agency name or logo

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Slide deck

- Built from approved website copy, not new language
- Overview, timeline, eligibility, prizes, how to enter
- Speaker notes for each presenter
- 508-compliant slides

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Final deck: content and branding

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

05

Q&A preparation

- Anticipated questions from the inbox and FAQ log
- Draft answer bank
- Assign who answers which topics
- Route policy and eligibility questions to the client

CLIENT PROVIDES
Answers to policy and eligibility questions

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Dry run

- Full rehearsal with timing
- Agency speakers join
- Test captions, polls, recording and screen share
- Backup plan if a speaker drops

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Deliver the session

- Host and moderate
- Live captions and recording on
- Capture every question word for word
- Defer anything uncertain to the written follow-up

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

08

Post-event follow-up

- Edit recording; add captions and transcript
- Written answer to every question asked
- Update the site FAQ
- Attendance and registration report

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Recording, transcript and written answers before public posting

Outreach Lead — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Agenda
Locks speakers before promotion names them

03 · Promotion
Any use of the agency name needs approval

04 · Deck
Reuses approved site copy to keep the review short

08 · Follow-up
Written answers become public guidance

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION

WORKFLOW 07 OF 15

Competitor Management

SECTION 07 · BEFORE YOU START

Competitor Management

FedTech is the single point of contact for every solver question, eligibility call and dispute. Most answers come from approved material; policy questions go to the client. Every answer either keeps the field level or tilts it.

Best practices

01 **Get the escalation matrix approved before launch.** Everyone should know which questions FedTech answers and which go to the client.

02 **Send the client a draft answer, not just the question.** A yes or a small edit comes back far faster than a blank page.

03 **Answer only from approved rules and FAQ.** Anything new is a rule interpretation and needs the client.

04 **Publish FAQ updates on a fixed schedule.** One team's question becomes everyone's answer at the same time.

05 **Log every inquiry and decision.** When a dispute comes, the record is your defense.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Which questions can we answer, and which go to the agency?
- What response time do we commit to?
- Who decides eligibility disputes and appeals?

CLIENT GATES 01 Escalation rules · 04 FAQ updates · 06 Disputes

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 07 OF 15

Competitor Management

FedTech is the single point of contact for every solver question, eligibility determination and dispute. Most questions are answered from approved material. Policy questions go to the client, and every decision leaves a record.

FEDTECH LEAD	Challenge Operations Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Launch to closeout
FINAL OUTPUT	Audit-ready inquiry record

3 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Inbox & escalation rules

- Set up a monitored inbox and published response-time commitment
- Define which questions FedTech answers and which go to the client
- Write the dispute process against the published rules

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Escalation matrix, response standard and dispute process

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Triage & respond

- Log every inquiry with a timestamp
- Answer from approved rules and FAQ only
- Route anything new or policy-related per the matrix

Ops Lead

○ CLIENT INPUT

03

Policy questions

- Send the client a draft answer, not just the question
- Hold the reply to the solver until the client responds
- Queue the answer for the next FAQ update

CLIENT PROVIDES
Decisions on policy and rule interpretation

Ops Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

04

FAQ updates

- Batch new answers on a fixed schedule
- Post on the site so every solver sees the same answer
- Mirror to Challenge.gov if rules are affected

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
New FAQ entries that interpret the rules

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

05

Eligibility determinations

- Screen registrants against the published eligibility rules
- Decide clear cases from the rules
- Send borderline cases to the client with a recommendation

CLIENT PROVIDES
Rulings on borderline eligibility cases

Ops Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Disputes

- Acknowledge the dispute and gather the facts
- Assess it against the published rules
- Draft a resolution with its rationale

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Each dispute resolution before it is sent

Ops Lead — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Records & metrics

- Audit-ready log of inquiries, decisions and disputes
- Response-time metrics
- Recurring questions flagged to improve site copy

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

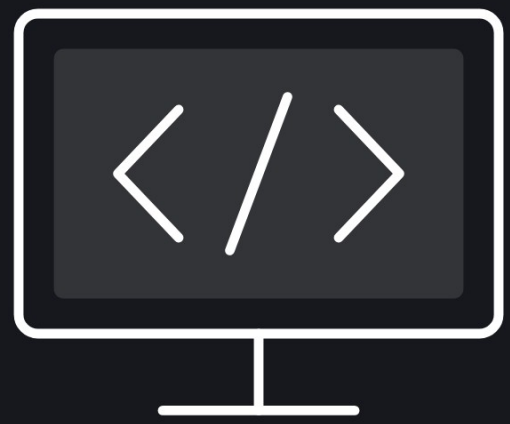
01 · Escalation rules
Set once at launch, so most answers need no review

04 · FAQ
Published answers act as rule guidance for everyone

06 · Disputes
The client stands behind every resolution

Recurring questions also feed the webinar topics (Workflow 08)

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION



WORKFLOW 08 OF 15

Technical Webinar

SECTION 08 · BEFORE YOU START

Technical Webinar

A deeper session for registered teams, led by subject-matter experts, on the technical areas where solvers struggle most. Its biggest risk is a verbal clarification that the published rules don't support.

Best practices

01 **Pick topics from real confusion.** The inbox, FAQ log and early submissions show where teams are stuck.

02 **Screen presenters for judging conflicts first.** A reviewer who coaches teams on air can't score them later.

03 **Check every slide against the rules and rubric.** No new requirement should ever be introduced out loud.

04 **Keep a recorded fallback for every live demo.** Hardware and connections fail on the day.

05 **Turn every question into a written answer for all teams.** Client-approved, then posted, because it acts as a rule interpretation.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Which technical gaps are teams struggling with?
- Which presenters are free of conflicts with likely entrants?
- What can be shared without favoring some teams?

CLIENT GATES 02 Presenters · 03 Technical content · 07 Written Q&A

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 08 OF 15

Technical Webinar

A deeper session for registered teams, led by subject-matter experts. It covers the technical areas where solvers struggle most. The risk is clarifying something verbally that the rules don't say, so the content gate matters most here.

FEDTECH LEAD	Review Lead + Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency technical leads
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	Webinar, recording, written Q&A

3 APPROVAL GATES

1 INPUT POINT

CLIENT INPUT

01

Define technical objectives

- Mine the inbox, FAQ log and early submissions for where solvers struggle
- Set two or three learning goals
- Pick a format: talks, live demo or panel

CLIENT PROVIDES
Technical priorities from the agency's technical leads

Review Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Presenters & conflict check

- Identify SMEs from the agency, partners and FedTech
- Screen against reviewer/judge roles and the entrant list
- Confirm availability and the presentation brief

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Presenter lineup

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Technical content

- Presenters draft; FedTech fits it to the template and plain language
- Check every claim against the published rules and rubric
- No new requirements introduced verbally
- 508-compliant slides and demo materials

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Technical accuracy and consistency with official rules

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Promotion to registered teams

- Targeted email to registrants and partner channels
- Reuse promotion templates already approved for the info session
- Add the webinar to the site's events page

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Rehearsal & demo check

- Timing run with every presenter
- Recorded fallback for any live demo
- Assign Q&A roles by topic
- Captioning and recording test

Review Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Deliver the webinar

- Host and moderate; SMEs field technical questions
- Capture every question word for word
- Rules or eligibility questions: "we'll answer in writing for everyone"

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Publish written Q&A

- Written answer to every question, posted for all solvers
- Recording, slides and transcript
- Update the site FAQ
- Attendance report

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Written answers. They act as rule interpretations.

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Presenters
A judge who presents creates a conflict; screen first

03 · Content
The highest-risk gate: verbal content can change the rules

07 · Written Q&A
Keeps every team on equal footing

Promotion reuses approved templates, so it carries no new gate

PHASE 2 · RUN THE COMPETITION

WORKFLOW 09 OF 15

Judging & Technical Review

SECTION 09 · BEFORE YOU START

Judging & Technical Review

Expert reviewers score submissions against an approved rubric, and federal judges make every award decision. A fair, documented review is what makes the results defensible, and its dates drive the winner announcement.

Best practices

01 **Lock the rubric before the stage opens.** Never change criteria or weights once solvers are building to them.

02 **Recruit a bench deeper than the seats.** In a small expert field, a reviewer dropping out mid-stage is likely.

03 **Screen conflicts against the entrant list every stage.** New entrants bring new conflicts.

04 **Discuss divergent scores; don't average them away.** A wide split usually means the rubric or the reviewers saw something important.

05 **Federal judges decide; everyone else advises.** Keep the decision record so the agency can stand behind every award.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who are the federal judges, and are they confirmed?
- How many reviewers does the expected volume need?
- How are conflicts screened and recorded?

CLIENT GATES 01 Rubric & weights · 07 Federal judging

Full steps on the next sheet →

Judging & Technical Review

Expert reviewers score submissions against an approved rubric, and federal judges make every award decision. Marketing rarely touches this workflow, but its dates and outcomes drive the winner announcement.

FEDTECH LEAD	Review Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + federal judges
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks per stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Verified winners per stage

2 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Rubric & scoring design

- Benchmark comparable prizes; ask the client what didn't work
- Criteria, weights and anchored 1–5 scale
- Calibrate with reviewers; method on the next pages

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Rubric and weights, before the stage opens

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

02

Reviewer & judge recruitment

- Recruit SME reviewers for each technical area
- Apply designated-country rules (FAR 52.225-5) if required
- Bench deeper than the seats needed

CLIENT PROVIDES
Federal judge names and reviewer nominations

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Conflict screening & onboarding

- Screen for conflicts against the entrant list every stage
- NDAs signed
- Rubric training before scoring opens

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Submission screening

- Check completeness and compliance
- Confirm eligibility of each entrant
- Assign reviewers on the platform

Ops Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Independent scoring

- Blind, independent scores on the platform
- Track progress against the scoring deadline
- Replace a reviewer from the bench if one drops out

Review Lead

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Reconciliation

- Moderated session to discuss divergent scores
- Record of the discussion, not just averages
- Score packet prepared for federal judges

Review Lead

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

07

Federal judging

- Brief judges on scores and reconciliation record
- Facilitate the judging session
- Document the decisions and their rationale

CLIENT DECIDES
Every award. Federal judges only.

Review Lead — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

08

Winner verification & prize handoff

- Re-verify eligibility of each winner
- Collect payment information as the agency directs
- Hand the winner list to the announcement workflow

CLIENT PROVIDES
Prize payment (usually paid directly by the agency)

Ops Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

01 · Rubric
Locked before the stage opens, never mid-review. Template A9

07 · Award decisions
Federal judges only; FedTech and SMEs advise

Marketing: winner names stay confidential until Workflow 11 clears them

Repeats every stage

WORKFLOW 09 · DEVELOPING THE EVALUATION RUBRIC

How to build the evaluation rubric

Start from evidence, not a blank page: what comparable prizes did, how many entries to expect, and what this client disliked last time. Then draft, test with reviewers, and get approval before the stage opens.

FedTech step
Client input
Client approval gate

01 Benchmark FEDTECH

Pull 3 to 5 recent, comparable prizes: same sector, similar purse, similar stage type. Record their published criteria, weights and entry numbers.

PRODUCES Benchmark table (next page)

02 Size the funnel FEDTECH

Estimate registrations, submissions, finalists and winners from the benchmarks. Set reviewer numbers from the expected submissions.

PRODUCES Expected volumes · reviewer plan

03 Ask what didn't work CLIENT INPUT

Run the debrief questions on the right with the client before drafting. Their past frustrations are the fastest route to a rubric they will approve.

PRODUCES Debrief notes · must-avoid list

04 Draft FEDTECH

4 to 6 scored criteria tied to the challenge goals, weights that add to 100, a 1 to 5 scale with written anchors, and pass/fail screens kept separate.

PRODUCES Draft rubric (template A9)

05 Test and calibrate FEDTECH

Score 2 or 3 sample or past entries together. Where scores spread by 2 or more points, rewrite the anchor, not the score.

PRODUCES Calibrated rubric · scoring guide

06 Approve and publish CLIENT APPROVAL

The client approves criteria and weights before the stage opens. Publish them in the rules; keep the scoring guide internal if agreed.

PRODUCES Approved rubric · rules text

07 Review after each stage FEDTECH

Check score spread, reconciliation notes and solver questions. Adjust only between stages, never during one.

PRODUCES Changes for the next stage

STEP 3 · CLIENT DEBRIEF: WHAT DIDN'T WORK?

- [ ] Which rubrics or evaluation approaches from past challenges did you not like, and why?
- [ ] Which criteria could judges not tell apart, or rewarded polish over substance?
- [ ] Where did reviewers disagree most, and how was it settled?
- [ ] Looking back, were the winners the right choice? What would you weight differently?
- [ ] Was the reviewer workload realistic? How long did each entry take?
- [ ] Are any criteria required by the agency, or off-limits?
- [ ] Which evidence do you trust most: data, a demonstration, letters of support?
- [ ] Did solvers complain about unclear criteria or feedback?

Record the answers as a "must avoid" list and check the draft rubric against it before calibration.

RULES OF THUMB

Keep pass/fail eligibility screens out of the score.

Every criterion names the evidence a reviewer should look for.

At least 2, ideally 3, independent reviewers per entry.

Reconcile large disagreements; never just average them.

Federal judges make every award decision.

STEP 2 · SIZING THE REVIEW

Review hours = submissions × reviewers per entry × hours per review

Illustration: 200 submissions × 3 reviewers × 1.5 hours = 900 hours, or 30 reviewers at 30 hours each. Replace the hours per review with the client's experience from the debrief.

Recent prize funnels: from registration to winners

Use these to size reviewer panels, set outreach targets and tell the client what to expect. Pick the 3 to 5 closest matches by sector, purse and stage type, and add newer ones as they publish.

CHALLENGE	SECTOR · PURSE	REGISTERED	SUBMISSIONS	FINALISTS	WINNERS	NOTES
XPRIZE Carbon Removal XPRIZE · global · 2021–25	Climate tech $100M	1,300+ teams	—	20 finalists	**4 grand prizes + 2 XFACTOR**	Also 15 milestone and 23 student awards
XPRIZE Quantum Applications XPRIZE · global · 2024–27	Quantum $5M	417 registered teams	133 (round 1)	20 semifinalists → 7 finalists	**Pending**	Wildcard round later raised finalists to 12, from 195 submissions
NASA LunaRecycle, Phase 1 NASA Centennial Challenges · 2024–25	Space Up to $50K–$75K per winner	1,200+	~200	—	**17**	50 judges; international teams recognized but not paid
Longitude Prize on AMR Nesta Challenge Works · UK · 2014–24	Diagnostics £8M	250+ teams	~50 detailed submissions	—	**1**	Single winner-takes-all prize
NIA Start-Up Challenge NIH (NIA) · 2025	Aging · health start-ups $65K pitch-stage prizes	—	275	21	**7**	
DEBUT Challenge NIH (NIBIB) and VentureWell · 2025	Biomedical design · students —	—	123 teams	—	**14 + 5 honorable mentions**	534 students
KidneyX EMPOWER: Living Link HHS · 2026	Health IT $4M	—	85+	—	**9**	
American-Made Solar Prize, Round 7 DOE (SETO) · 2023–24	Clean energy $50K–$500K per stage	—	Not published	20 semifinalists → 10 finalists	**2**	
NIH Quantum Sensing (Qu-BIT), Stage 1 NIH (NCATS) · 2025	Quantum · biomedical Up to $20K each	—	Not published	—	**Up to 10, advancing to Stage 2**	Parent program of Qu-SAFE
EIC Transition (funding call, for comparison) European Innovation Council · 2024	Deep tech Grant funding	—	413 (390 evaluated)	—	**40 funded**	A grant call, not a prize; shows typical selectivity

What the numbers suggest

~1 in 6
registrants submitted
LunaRecycle: ~200 submissions from 1,200+ registrations. Plan outreach for a large drop between sign-up and submission.

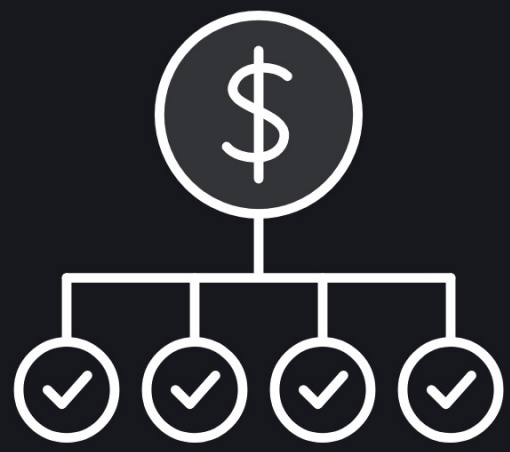
5–15%
of submissions reach the final round
NIA: 21 of 275 (8%). XPRIZE Quantum: 20 of 133 semifinalists (15%), 7 finalists (5%).

3–11%
of submissions win
NIA 7 of 275 (3%) · LunaRecycle 17 of ~200 (9%) · KidneyX 9 of 85+ (≤11%) · DEBUT 14 of 123 (11%).

~10%
selected in a competitive EU call
EIC Transition: 40 of 413. Useful when a client compares a prize with a grant program.

Counts as published by sponsors and press, gathered October 2026 through web searches; sources are on the references pages. Stages and definitions differ between prizes, so treat ratios as planning ranges, not targets. "—" means not published or not applicable. Refresh this table with sector-specific prizes for each new challenge.

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT



WORKFLOW 10 OF 15

Prize Purse Distribution

SECTION 10 · BEFORE YOU START

Prize Purse Distribution

Some RFTPs have the agency pay prizes directly; others make FedTech the payer and fold the purse into our price. When we pay, the purse is often most of the task order's value, and a payment error is the costliest mistake we can make.

Best practices

01 **Read who pays before you price.** The RFTP states the payer phase by phase, and later phases are often left open.

02 **Keep the purse separate from fees.** Show award amounts per phase in the price narrative, and hold prize funds apart from operating cash.

03 **Verify eligibility before the announcement, not after.** Withdrawing a public prize is far harder than withholding one.

04 **No money moves without a signed-off payee list.** The client confirms teams and amounts in writing, CoECI COR copied.

05 **Pay one designated payee per team, and record everything.** Award amounts per solver feed CoECI's post-competition reporting.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who pays the winners: FedTech or the agency?
- Which payee and tax documents are needed, and when?
- What happens if a winner is ineligible or declines?

CLIENT GATES 01 Structure & payer · 03 Prize terms · 06 Payee list

Worked example and full steps follow →

WORKFLOW 10 · WORKED EXAMPLE · NOIS3-085

NSF Quantum Algorithm Challenge: who pays what

This RFTP makes FedTech the payer for the Phase 1 purse and leaves Phase 2 open. Read every RFTP the same way: phase by phase, who pays, and what goes in the price.

CLIENT	**U.S. National Science Foundation**
NOT TO EXCEED	**$1,300,000**
AUTHORITY	**COMPETES; CHIPS and Science**
ELIGIBILITY	**U.S. only**

The Phase 1 purse is 77% of the price ceiling

Not-to-exceed value of $1,300,000, as given for pricing

"Everything else" covers management, execution and external expenses for the whole task order. If the purse rises to $2,000,000, it is added by task order modification.

Phase 1 · Proposal

IN THE PRICE

$1,000,000

- Up to 40 winners at $25,000 each; a better structure may be proposed
- **FedTech pays** and disburses to each winning team
- May increase to $2,000,000 (e.g., 40 at $50,000) by modification; price assumes $1,000,000
- Submissions open through March 2027

Phase 2 · Development

EXCLUDED

To be decided

- Purse and number of prizes not yet set
- **Payer not yet decided:** FedTech or the Government
- Do not include in the proposed price
- Winners pair with NSF industry partners

Phase 3 · Scaling

NOT IN TASK ORDER

Informational

- Duration, purse and prizes not yet set
- Outside the current task order

What the RFTP asks of FedTech on prizes

2.1.1.2 Disburse the Phase 1 purse to each winning team, and develop the rules, terms and conditions

5.2.6.1 Show individual and total award amounts per phase in the price narrative

2.1.6.2 Verify winner eligibility: U.S. entity or citizen/permanent resident; not a federal entity or NSF employee; ethics check for other federal staff

4.2 · 4.3.10 Report each solver's placement and award amount within one month of the winner announcement

2.1.6.1.4 Collect NSF research security certification before the Phase 1 prize announcement

2.1 All products require NSF approval before release, including prize terms and announcements

WORKFLOW 10 OF 15

Prize Purse Distribution

When the RFTP makes FedTech the payer, the prize purse becomes the largest number in our price and the biggest financial risk on the task order. This workflow covers setting the structure, verifying winners and getting every dollar to the right team.

FEDTECH LEAD	PM + finance
CLIENT COUNTERPART	Client agency + CoECI COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Proposal to final report
FINAL OUTPUT	Every winner paid and reported

3 APPROVAL GATES

1 INPUT POINT

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Set structure & payer

- Read who pays each phase: FedTech or the agency
- Number of winners and amount per prize, per phase
- Propose a better structure if the RFTP invites it

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Prize structure and payer for each phase

PM — At award

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Price & ring-fence the purse

- Include the purse in the fixed price only where FedTech pays
- Show award amounts per phase in the price narrative
- Hold prize funds apart from operating cash
- A purse increase comes by task order modification

PM + finance

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Prize terms in the rules

- Amounts, eligibility and payment timing
- One designated payee per team
- Winners are responsible for their own taxes
- Required certifications, such as research security

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Prize and eligibility terms in the official rules

Ops Lead — With WF 02

○ CLIENT INPUT

04

Verify winner eligibility

- Check each winner against the RFTP's eligibility rules
- Collect required certifications before the announcement
- Send borderline cases to the client with a recommendation

CLIENT PROVIDES
Rulings on borderline eligibility cases

Ops Lead

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Collect payee details

- Signed winner acceptance
- Tax forms and banking details, collected securely
- Handle personal data per the Privacy Act terms in the rules

Finance

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Confirm the payee list

- Final list: team, payee, amount, placement
- Total matches the approved purse
- Sent in writing, CoECI COR copied

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Final payee list and amounts. No money moves without it.

PM — Review: [X] days

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Disburse prizes

- Pay each team's designated payee
- Record date, amount and method for every payment
- Resolve returned or failed payments quickly

Finance

☐ FEDTECH INTERNAL

08

Report & reconcile

- Report each solver's placement and award amount to CoECI
- Reconcile paid total against the purse
- Issue year-end tax forms as finance advises

PM + finance

GATE SEQUENCE

01 · Structure & payer
Settles who pays each phase before anything is priced

03 · Prize terms
Approved with the official rules in Workflow 02

06 · Payee list
The last check before money moves

Depends on: Judging step 07 (awards decided). Feeds Workflow 11 (announcement)

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT

WORKFLOW 11 OF 15

Winner Announcement

SECTION 11 · BEFORE YOU START

Winner Announcement

The public moment for each stage's results. Agency public affairs usually controls timing and clearance. Our job is to have everything ready so the release goes out in the same hour on every channel.

Best practices

01 **Learn public affairs' clearance lead time at kickoff.** It is often the longest wait in the whole workflow.

02 **Draft content while judging is still underway.** Templates with placeholder names let clearance start before the winners are known.

03 **Get winner consent before release.** Names, quotes, photos and affiliations should all be confirmed by the teams.

04 **Release everywhere in the same hour.** Site, Challenge.gov, social and email go out together.

05 **Route media inquiries to public affairs.** FedTech supports the story; the agency tells it.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Who in the agency clears the announcement, and how long does it take?
- Who notifies winners, and what may they say before release?
- What do non-winners receive?

CLIENT GATES 03 Announcement content

Full steps on the next sheet →

Winner Announcement

The public moment for each stage's results. The agency's public affairs office usually controls timing and clearance. Our job is to have everything ready so the release goes out the same hour on every channel.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + agency public affairs
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks per stage
FINAL OUTPUT	Coordinated public release

1 APPROVAL GATE

1 INPUT POINT

CLIENT INPUT

01

Announcement plan

- Target date, embargo and channel list
- Learn public affairs' clearance steps and lead time
- Decide who announces: agency, FedTech or both

CLIENT PROVIDES
Public affairs contact, clearance timeline, preferred date

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Notify winners privately

- Notify winners under embargo
- Collect bios, photos and team details
- Notify non-winners on the same day as the public release

Ops Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Announcement content

- Press release or blog post
- Winner profiles and site update
- Social posts and graphics
- Challenge.gov winner posting

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All announcement content, through public affairs clearance

Outreach Lead Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Winner consent

- Winners confirm their profiles and any quotes
- Photo and name-use permissions on file
- Confirm affiliations are spelled correctly

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Coordinated release

- Publish site, Challenge.gov and social together
- Email registrants and partners
- Verify every link once live

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Amplification

- Partner newsletters and society channels
- Reuse approved content only
- Route media inquiries to agency public affairs

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Results reporting

- Reach and engagement metrics
- Press pickup log
- Included in the stage-close report

Outreach Lead

GATE SEQUENCE

03 · Content
Public affairs clearance often takes longest; start it early

Depends on: Judging step 07 (awards decided)

Winner names are confidential until release

Repeats every stage

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT

WORKFLOW 12 OF 15

In-Person Convening

SECTION 12 · BEFORE YOU START

In-Person Convening

An in-person event where winners present and meet the funders, adopters and program staff who can carry their work forward. Not every task order includes one, but when it does, it is the most visible deliverable.

Best practices

01 **Confirm scope and budget before planning.** Know what the task order covers, such as staff travel versus participant travel.

02 **Get venue and date approved before signing anything.** Venue contracts are the hardest commitment to undo.

03 **Design the agenda for what happens next.** Put winners in front of funders, adopters and SBIR/STTR staff, not just an audience.

04 **Coach winners on their presentations.** A rehearsed five-minute pitch does more for them than the award itself.

05 **Capture and hand off every introduction.** The contacts made in the room belong to the agency's network afterward.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- What is the event for: showcase, partnering or recognition?
- Who attends, and who pays for travel?
- Which agency approvals does an in-person event need?

CLIENT GATES 02 Venue · 03 Agenda · 05 Materials · 08 Recap

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 12 OF 15

In-Person Convening

An in-person event where winners present and meet the people who can carry their work forward: funders, adopters and program staff. Not every task order includes one. When it does, it is the most visible deliverable.

FEDTECH LEAD	Outreach Lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR + program leadership
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] months
FINAL OUTPUT	Event, recap, contact handoff

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

Goals & format

- What the event must achieve beyond showcasing
- Attendance target and audience mix
- Length, region and date window

CLIENT PROVIDES
Goals, date constraints, leadership availability

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Venue & logistics

- Shortlist venues near agency stakeholders
- AV, catering and physical accessibility
- Budget check: what the task order covers

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Venue and date, before contracting

Outreach Lead | Review: [X] days

CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Agenda & speakers

- Winner presentations
- Sessions with funders, SBIR/STTR staff and adopters
- Agency leadership remarks
- Structured networking time

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Agenda and speaker lineup

Outreach Lead | Review: [X] days

CLIENT INPUT

04

Invitations & registration

- Build the invite list
- Registration page and confirmations
- Travel details for winners, if covered

CLIENT PROVIDES
Agency invitees and VIPs

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

05

Event materials

- Printed program and signage
- Slide template and name badges
- Accessible digital versions

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
All branded and printed materials

Outreach Lead | Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Run of show & rehearsal

- Minute-by-minute run of show
- Winner presentation coaching
- AV walkthrough on site

Outreach Lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Deliver the event

- Staff registration and sessions
- Photography and recording, with consent
- Capture contacts and introductions made

Outreach Lead

CLIENT APPROVAL

08

Follow-up & recap

- Attendee survey
- Public recap: blog, photos, video
- Hand off contacts and introductions to the agency

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Public recap content before posting

Outreach Lead | Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Venue
Approve before signing any venue contract

03 · Agenda
Locks leadership calendars early

05 · Materials
Print deadlines drive this review window

08 · Recap
Public content, same rule as every other workflow

PHASE 3 · RESULTS & CLOSEOUT

WORKFLOW 13 OF 15

Reporting & Closeout

SECTION 13 · BEFORE YOU START

Reporting & Closeout

The contractual record of the challenge, from kickoff to the post-award evaluation survey. It runs behind every other workflow for the whole period of performance, and it is how the COR sees our work.

Best practices

01 **Use kickoff to set every gate.** Name a client reviewer and a review window for each one, in writing.

02 **Raise any slip with options, not just a warning.** A risk to a public date reaches the COR with a recommended fix.

03 **Feed metrics in as you go.** Outreach, inquiry and review numbers should flow into monthly reports, not be rebuilt each month.

04 **Ask early about Paperwork Reduction Act clearance.** If the post-award survey needs it, clearance can take months.

05 **Build the network handoff as you go.** Keep the SME roster and stakeholder contacts current, not reconstructed at closeout.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- What does the COR need in each report, and by when?
- Which success measures does the agency report on?
- Who receives the records and data at closeout?

CLIENT GATES 01 Project plan · 03 Monthly reports · 04 Stage-close reports · 08 Final report

Full steps on the next sheet →

Reporting & Closeout

The contractual record of the challenge, from kickoff to the post-award evaluation survey. It runs in the background of every other workflow. The metrics marketing collects end up here.

FEDTECH LEAD	Program Manager
CLIENT COUNTERPART	COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Full period of performance
FINAL OUTPUT	Final report + network handoff

4 APPROVAL GATES

2 INPUT POINTS

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

01

Kickoff & project plan

- Kickoff with the COR soon after award
- Baselined schedule with every public date
- Report templates and meeting cadence
- Named reviewer and review window for every gate

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Project plan, schedule and report formats

PM — Review: [X] days

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

02

Status calls

- Weekly during active stages; biweekly otherwise
- Upcoming gates and decisions needed
- Any slip on a public date raised with options

PM

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

03

Monthly progress reports

- Participation and outreach metrics
- Review status, risks and spend
- Inquiry volume and response times

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Each monthly report

PM — Review: [X] days

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Stage-close reports

- Submissions, scoring and winners
- Outreach and announcement results
- Lessons learned for the next stage

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Each stage-close report

PM — Review: [X] days

○ CLIENT INPUT

05

Post-award evaluation survey

- Survey of winners and participants after the final award
- Ask the client whether Paperwork Reduction Act clearance is needed
- Results summarized for the final report

CLIENT PROVIDES
Questions the agency needs answered

PM

□ FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Network handoff package

- SME and reviewer roster
- Stakeholder and partner contacts
- Challenge records and platform data export

PM

○ CLIENT INPUT

07

Winner follow-up

- Check-ins with winners at 6 and 12 months
- Track pilots, adoption and follow-on funding
- Past the period of performance, hand the plan to the client and CoECI

CLIENT PROVIDES
Which outcomes to track and any path to test or adopt solutions

PM

◆ CLIENT APPROVAL

08

Final report & closeout

- Full challenge results and outcomes
- Evaluation survey findings
- Recommendations for future challenges
- Close the site and listing per the agency's wishes

CLIENT ACCEPTS
Final report, including the network handoff package

PM — Review: [X] days

GATE SEQUENCE

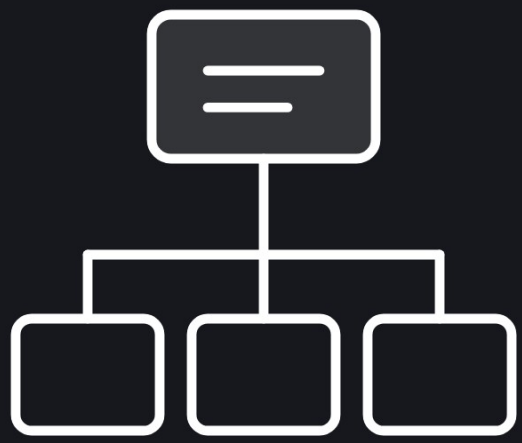
01 · Project plan
Sets every other workflow's review windows

03 · Monthly reports
Marketing metrics feed in here

04 · Stage-close
One per stage, after winners are announced

08 · Final report
Closes the task order

ACROSS ALL PHASES



WORKFLOW 14 OF 15

Subcontractor Management

SECTION 14 · BEFORE YOU START

Subcontractor Management

Partners extend what FedTech can deliver, but FedTech stays fully responsible for their work. This workflow runs from the proposal to closeout, alongside every other workflow in the playbook.

Best practices

01 **Flow down every obligation FedTech carries.** Section 508, designated-country rules, conflict of interest, NDA and data rights all go into the subcontract.

02 **The client and CoECI hear one voice: FedTech's.** Subs never contact either one directly without us.

03 **Review sub work before the client sees it.** Their deliverable is our deliverable.

04 **Track the work share monthly.** Confirm FedTech performs more than half the work while there is still time to correct it.

05 **Never change a named sub without approval.** The client agency approves in writing, with CoECI copied.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Has the client approved each sub and its scope?
- Who manages each sub day to day, and how is the work checked?
- Does every sub know the CoECI communications rule?

CLIENT GATES 02 Named subs at award · 06 Any change to a sub

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 14 OF 15

Subcontractor Management

How FedTech brings partners onto a task order and keeps them accountable. FedTech holds full responsibility for everything a subcontractor delivers, and the client and CoECI hear one voice: ours.

FEDTECH LEAD	Program Manager
CLIENT COUNTERPART	Client agency + CoECI COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Proposal to closeout
FINAL OUTPUT	Sub work delivered and closed

2 APPROVAL GATES

0 INPUT POINTS

FEDTECH INTERNAL

01

Identify & vet partner

- Confirm the capability gap the partner fills
- Conflict-of-interest check
- Confirm they can accept every flow-down clause
- Teaming agreement before the proposal

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

Disclose in proposal

- Name, role and value of each sub
- Relationship and prior work together
- Show FedTech performs more than half the work

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
The named subcontractors, through the award

PM — At award

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Execute subcontract

- Fixed price, defined deliverables, milestone payments
- Flow-downs: Section 508, FAR 52.225-5, conflict of interest, NDA, data rights
- Signed at task order award

PM + contracts

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

Onboard

- Kickoff: who does what, by when
- Agency branding only
- CoECI's six expectations apply to sub staff too
- No direct contact with the client or CoECI without FedTech

PM

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

Manage delivery

- Weekly check-ins against milestones
- FedTech reviews every sub deliverable before the client sees it
- Escalate slips early

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

06

Changes to a sub

- Replacing, adding or dropping a sub
- Changing a sub's scope or key staff
- Request in writing to the client agency, CoECI COR copied

CLIENT AGENCY SIGNS OFF ON
Any change to a named sub, its scope or key staff

PM — Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Invoice & track work share

- Pay on accepted milestones only
- Confirm each month that FedTech performs more than half the work

PM + finance

FEDTECH INTERNAL

08

Closeout

- Final deliverables accepted
- Records, data and access returned
- Performance review feeds the final report

PM

GATE SEQUENCE

02 · Named subs
Accepted by the client agency as part of the award

06 · Any change
Client agency approval, in writing, CoECI copied

Runs from proposal to closeout, alongside every other workflow

Subs never speak for FedTech with the client or CoECI

ACROSS PHASES · PM QUALITY CHECK

WORKFLOW 15 OF 15

Pipeline & Outreach Quality Check

SECTION 15 · BEFORE YOU START

Pipeline & Outreach Quality Check

A PM-led check that runs separately from marketing's outreach. The PM maps the solver ecosystem, writes down how many entries we need and from where, and tests marketing's outreach plan and network partners against those assumptions before launch and every week after.

Best practices

01 **Separate doing from checking.** Marketing runs outreach (Workflow 05); the PM or a named QA lead checks it. The same person should not do both.

02 **Write the assumptions down first.** Segments, sizes and conversion rates are guesses until tested. Record each with its source and confidence.

03 **Work backward from the winners.** Winners, then finalists, submissions, registrations and reach, using the benchmark ratios in Workflow 09.

04 **Qualify partners by reach, not list size.** A partner counts only if it reaches a target segment and commits in writing.

05 **Set triggers before launch.** Agree the weekly numbers that prompt a change of course, so a slow week becomes a decision, not a debate.

KEY QUESTIONS TO ANSWER WITH THE CLIENT

- Which solver segments must produce entries for the client to call this a success?
- What does the client or CoECI already know about this community, and who entered before?
- Which agency networks and partners can we use, and which are off-limits?

CLIENT GATES 04 Ecosystem assumptions & pipeline targets

Full steps on the next sheet →

WORKFLOW 15 OF 15

Pipeline & Outreach Quality Check

A separate quality check on the application pipeline. The PM maps the ecosystem and sets assumptions; marketing builds outreach to meet them (Workflow 05); the QA lead tests the plan, the partners and the results against those assumptions.

FEDTECH LEAD	PM or named QA lead
CLIENT COUNTERPART	Client agency + CoECI COR
TYPICAL DURATION	Design session to final stage close
FINAL OUTPUT	A validated pipeline and outreach

1 APPROVAL GATE

2 INPUT POINTS

FEDTECH INTERNAL

01

Map the ecosystem

- Solver segments: labs, start-ups, industry, students, MSIs
- Intermediaries: societies, accelerators, journals, events
- Adopters and funders who should hear about it

OUTPUT
Ecosystem map (worksheet A10)

PM

CLIENT INPUT

02

Client and CoECI input

- Known communities and past entrants
- Agency networks we can use
- Partners or channels that are off-limits

CLIENT PROVIDES
Past entrant data, networks and constraints

PM

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

Set pipeline assumptions

- Work back from target winners using benchmark ratios
- Registrations needed, by segment
- Source and confidence for every number

OUTPUT
Assumptions log

PM

CLIENT APPROVAL

04

Agree targets

- Segment and pipeline targets become outreach KPIs
- Confidence levels shared honestly
- Triggers for a change of course

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
Ecosystem assumptions and pipeline targets

PM Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

05

QA marketing's outreach plan

- Every target segment has a channel and a message
- Volumes reach the registration targets
- Tracking set up per channel and segment

OUTPUT
Plan passed or returned with gaps (worksheet A11)

QA lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

06

Qualify network partners

- Score reach into target segments, fit and credibility
- Commitment in writing: what, when, how often
- Conflict and eligibility check

OUTPUT
Partner scorecard (worksheet A11)

QA lead

FEDTECH INTERNAL

07

Validate in market

- Weekly: registrations by segment against target
- Info session and matchmaking turnout from target segments
- Triggers hit become actions with an owner

OUTPUT
Weekly pipeline check

QA lead + marketing

CLIENT INPUT

08

Report and adjust

- Monthly pipeline view to client and CoECI
- Assumptions revised with evidence
- Lessons into the stage-close report

CLIENT PROVIDES
Decisions on extensions or re-targeting

PM

GATE SEQUENCE

04 · Pipeline targets
Agreed before marketing's outreach plan goes to the client (Workflow 05, gate 02)

Steps 01 to 04 run during the design session; 05 and 06 before launch

Step 07 runs weekly while each stage is open

Checks Workflow 05; uses the benchmarks in Workflow 09

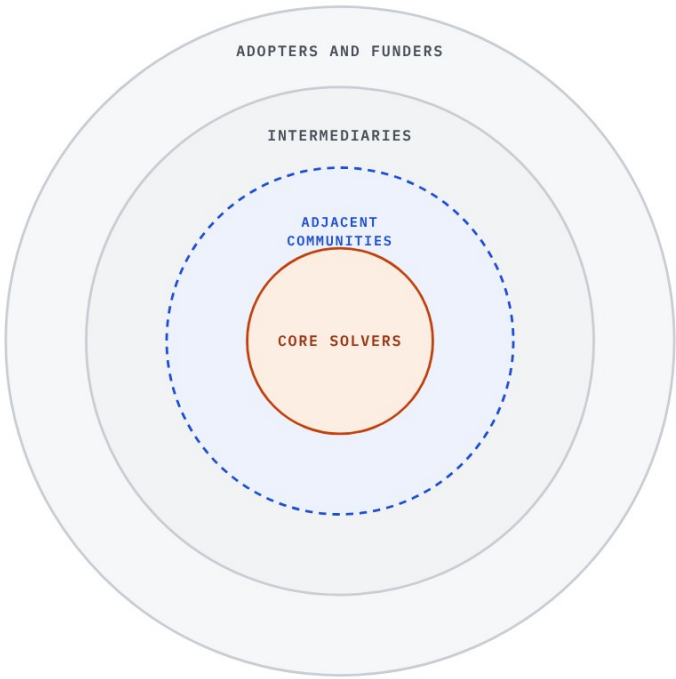
WORKFLOW 15 · WORKSHEET A10

Ecosystem map and pipeline assumptions

The PM fills this in during the design session and agrees the targets with the client (step 04). Marketing builds outreach to meet it; the QA lead checks against it.

CHALLENGE / STAGE	**[Name] · [Stage]**
QA LEAD	**[Name]**
AGREED WITH CLIENT	**[Date]**

A · ECOSYSTEM MAP (PLACE EACH SEGMENT IN A RING)



B · SEGMENT ASSUMPTIONS

SEGMENT	RING	EST. SIZE	TARGET REGISTRATIONS	CHANNELS AND PARTNERS	CONFIDENCE	EVIDENCE
[Segment]					H / M / L	
[Segment]					H / M / L	
[Segment]					H / M / L	
[Segment]					H / M / L	
[Segment]					H / M / L	
[Segment]					H / M / L	

Confidence: H = data from past challenges or the client; M = partner or desk research; L = judgment. Test every L in the first two weeks.

C · PIPELINE MODEL (WORK BACKWARD) · ILLUSTRATION

Winners	Target	**10**	—
Submissions	÷ win rate	**125**	8% (benchmarks: 3–11%)
Registrations	÷ submit rate	**~735**	17% (LunaRecycle ~1 in 6)
Engaged contacts	÷ sign-up rate	**[X]**	From your own campaign data
Reached contacts	÷ engagement rate	**[X]**	From your own campaign data

Ratios from the Workflow 09 benchmarks are planning ranges. Replace them with sector-specific numbers when you have them.

D · WEEKLY TRIGGERS (AGREE BEFORE LAUNCH)

Registrations at the halfway point	Below 40% of target	Add a partner push; review messaging for the lagging segment
Share from a priority segment	Below its target share	Direct outreach by name; ask the client to amplify
Info session turnout from target segments	Low against registrations	Follow up with recordings and office hours
Teams formed (multi-skill challenges)	Few cross-field teams	Run an extra matchmaking session

WORKFLOW 15 · WORKSHEET A11

Outreach plan and partner QA

The QA lead runs section A on marketing's draft outreach plan before it goes to the client, and section B on every proposed network partner. Gaps go back to marketing with an owner and a date.

CHALLENGE / STAGE	**[Name] · [Stage]**
QA LEAD	**[Name]**
AGREED WITH CLIENT	**[Date]**

A · OUTREACH PLAN QA (BEFORE THE PLAN GOES TO THE CLIENT)

☐ Every target segment has at least one channel or partner	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Message tested with someone from each priority segment	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Planned reach meets the registration target, using the agreed rates	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ A named target list exists for the smallest, most important segments	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Tracking set up for each channel and segment	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Copy approved by the client (Workflow 05, gate 03); Section 508 checked	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Eligibility rules reflected: no outreach promising what the rules exclude	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Partner commitments confirmed in writing	PASS	GAP	N/A
☐ Dates align with the info session, webinar and stage deadlines	PASS	GAP	N/A

Result: Pass · Pass with gaps (listed, owner, date) · Return to marketing. Record the QA lead, date and plan version.

B · NETWORK PARTNER SCORECARD

PARTNER	SEGMENT REACHED	EST. REACH	AUDIENCE FIT 1–5	CREDIBILITY 1–5	COMMITMENT 1–5	CONFLICT CHECK	DECISION
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop
[Partner]						Clear / Flag	Use / Hold / Drop

SCORING GUIDE

Audience fit. 5: the partner's audience is mostly a target segment. 1: little overlap.

Credibility. 5: trusted voice in that segment. 1: unknown to it.

Commitment. 5: named actions and dates in writing. 1: verbal interest only.

Use partners scoring 4 or more on fit and commitment. Hold anyone with a conflict until the client clears it.

Partner outreach that names the client agency or speaks for it uses client-approved copy. Any partner communication that involves the client copies CoECI and the backup CoECI contact.

ANNEX

FILL-IN TEMPLATES

Templates

Templates

Every fill-in template in this playbook, in one place. Copy a template for each challenge; never edit the master.

A1	**Challenge design document.** Word template with all 17 sections, guidance, key questions, glossary, compliance questions and approval block (Challenge_Design_Document_Template.docx)	Word file
A2	**Design document key questions.** The questions to confirm with the client, section by section	Pages 49–50
A3	**Challenge glossary.** Terms to agree with the client	Page 12
A4	**Design document checklist.** What the design document must settle, and the clearance schedule	Page 13
A5	**Rules and compliance questions.** Questions to settle with agency counsel	Page 14
A6	**Milestone readiness checks.** Go / no-go list for each milestone	Page 8
A7	**Risk register.** Risks, early warnings and owners	Page 9
A8	**Blank workflow sheet.** For any workflow a task order adds	Page 52
A9	**Evaluation rubric.** Criteria, weights, anchored scale, scoring rules and calibration record	Page 51
A10	**Ecosystem map and pipeline assumptions.** Segments, pipeline model and weekly triggers	Page 46
A11	**Outreach plan and partner QA.** QA checklist for marketing's plan and the partner scorecard	Page 47

The Word template is kept with this playbook in the FedTech deliverables folder.

Design document: key questions by section

The sections of the challenge design document template (A1), with the questions to confirm with the client in each. Tick a box when the client has answered in writing; log anything still open in section 17.

☐ Confirm with the client

CLIENT NAMED Section the client asked for

01 Challenge summary

WF A11

A one-page overview that a reviewer outside the program can read first. Write it last, once the other sections are settled.

- ☐ Could a reviewer outside the program understand the challenge from this page alone?
- ☐ Does every date and dollar figure match the sections below?
- ☐ Who is the single agency decision maker for this document?

02 Problem statement

WF 02 · 05

The gap the challenge closes, why a prize is the right tool, and what a winning solution must do.

- ☐ What specific gap does this close, and why is a prize the right tool rather than a grant or contract?
- ☐ What would a winning solution do that existing approaches cannot?
- ☐ What is out of scope?

03 Goals and success measures

WF 05 · 13

The outcomes the agency wants and how they will be measured during the challenge and after the award.

- ☐ Which outcome matters most: new solvers, a working solution, or a lasting community?
- ☐ What will the agency do with winning solutions after the award?
- ☐ Which measures does the agency report upward, and to whom?

04 Legal authority and approvals

WF 01 · 02

The authority the challenge runs under, who signs the rules, and the clearance path for this document.

- ☐ Which authority does the agency use: the America COMPETES Act (15 U.S.C. 3719) or its own?
- ☐ Who signs the official rules?
- ☐ Which offices clear this document, in what order, and how long does each take?

05 Eligibility

WF 02 · 07 · 10

Who may enter, who may win a prize, and who is excluded.

- ☐ Can people who cannot win a cash prize still enter or receive recognition?
- ☐ Can federal grantees or contractors enter, and can they use federal funds?
- ☐ Which organizations are excluded, including FedTech, subcontractors and judges' organizations?

06 Stage structure

WF 03 · 09

The stages of the competition, what each produces, and how teams move between them.

- ☐ Is each stage optional, or required to advance?
- ☐ Can new teams enter later stages?
- ☐ What must each stage produce to be worth judging?

07 Timeline

WF 02 · 04 · 09 · 11 · 12

CLIENT NAMED Every public and internal date, including clearance time.

- ☐ Which dates are fixed by the RFTP or by agency events?
- ☐ Does the schedule include clearance time for this document and for the winner announcement?
- ☐ Which time zone governs every deadline?

08 Submission requirements

WF 03 · 07

CLIENT NAMED What solvers submit at each stage, in what form, and how.

- ☐ What is the minimum needed to judge each stage fairly?
- ☐ Which forms (eligibility, consent, IP) are required at submission?
- ☐ What happens to late, incomplete or failed submissions?

09 Evaluation criteria and judging

WF 09

CLIENT NAMED The published criteria, the review process, and who decides.

- ☐ Which criteria and weights will be published, and which scoring guidance stays internal?
- ☐ Who are the federal judges, and are they confirmed?
- ☐ What happens if no entry merits an award, or scores tie?

Design document: key questions by section

The sections of the challenge design document template (A1), with the questions to confirm with the client in each. Tick a box when the client has answered in writing; log anything still open in section 17.

☐ Confirm with the client

CLIENT NAMED Section the client asked for

10 Prize structure

WF 10 · 03

CLIENT NAMED The purse, each award, any non-cash prizes, and who pays.

- ☐ Who pays winners: FedTech or the agency?
- ☐ Are there non-cash prizes such as mentoring, testing access or demo opportunities?
- ☐ Which payee and tax documents are needed, and when?

11 Intellectual property and data rights

WF 02 · 09 · 11

CLIENT NAMED Who owns submissions, any license to the government, and what may be published.

- ☐ Does the agency need any license to winning solutions?
- ☐ What may the agency publish about entries, names and images?
- ☐ How is confidential or proprietary material marked and protected?

12 Rules, terms and liability

WF 02 · 04

The legal terms solvers accept by entering.

- ☐ Must entrants carry liability insurance or show financial responsibility, and for how much?
- ☐ Who may change or cancel the challenge, and how are solvers told?
- ☐ Which conflicts or conduct disqualify an entrant?

13 Outreach and engagement

WF 05 · 06 · 08

Who we need to reach, through which channels, and the events that support them.

- ☐ Which solvers must we reach for this to succeed, and where are they?
- ☐ Which agency channels and partners will amplify, and who asks them?
- ☐ Who speaks for the agency at the info session and webinar?

14 Communications and publicity

WF 04 · 05 · 11

How the challenge and its results are announced, and who clears each release.

- ☐ Who clears public announcements, and how long does it take?
- ☐ What may winners say before the public release?
- ☐ Whose names and logos appear on the site, listing and materials?

15 Roles and responsibilities

WF All

Who decides, who approves, and who does the work.

- ☐ Who is the single agency decision maker?
- ☐ Who approves each gate, and within how many days?
- ☐ Who joins every call and receives every document?

16 Risks and assumptions

WF All

The assumptions this design makes and the risks that could delay or weaken the challenge.

- ☐ Which assumptions is this design making that the agency has not confirmed?
- ☐ What would cause us to delay launch?
- ☐ Which risks does the agency own rather than FedTech?

17 Open questions and decisions

WF All

A running log of open questions and the decisions that close them.

- ☐ Which questions block clearance?
- ☐ Who owns each answer, and by when?
- ☐ Which decisions change scope and need the COR in writing?

Also in the Word template

Document control and distribution · Annex A glossary · Annex B rules and compliance questions · Approval block for the agency, clearance, CoECI and FedTech.

ANNEX A9 · EVALUATION RUBRIC TEMPLATE

Evaluation rubric

Copy for each stage. Fill in from the benchmark review and the client debrief, then calibrate with reviewers before the client approves it.

CHALLENGE / STAGE	**[Name] · [Stage]**
VERSION	**[v0.X] · [Date]**
APPROVED BY	**[Client name] · [Date]**

A · PASS / FAIL SCREENS (NOT SCORED)

- ☐ Submitted before the deadline, through the platform
- ☐ All required forms complete and signed
- ☐ Entrant eligible under the rules
- ☐ Within the challenge scope
- ☐ Format and length limits met
- ☐ No disqualifying conflict of interest

C · SCORING SCALE (1 TO 5)

5	**Strong**	Fully meets the criterion with clear evidence; no material weaknesses
4	**Good**	Meets the criterion; minor gaps
3	**Adequate**	Meets the criterion in part; notable gaps
2	**Weak**	Major gaps or unsupported claims
1	**Poor**	Does not address the criterion

B · SCORED CRITERIA · WEIGHTS ADD TO 100%

CRITERION	WHAT IT REWARDS	EVIDENCE TO LOOK FOR	WEIGHT	1 · POOR	3 · ADEQUATE	5 · STRONG
Technical merit and feasibility	Sound approach that can work as described	Data, methods, prototype results	%	*Approach unclear or unlikely to work*	*Plausible, with gaps in evidence*	*Well evidenced and clearly feasible*
Innovation	Clear advance over current practice	Comparison with existing approaches	%			
Impact on the challenge goal	Addresses the stated problem and users	Use case, users, measured benefit	%			
Team and plan	Team can deliver the next stage	Roles, milestones, resources	%			
Path to adoption	Realistic route to use beyond the prize	Partners, cost, regulatory path	%			
[Add or replace]			%			

First row shows example anchors. Write anchors for every criterion before calibration; anchors describe what a reviewer sees, not adjectives.

D · SCORING RULES

Weighted score = sum of (score ÷ 5 × weight). Maximum 100.

[2–3] independent reviewers per entry; reviewers blind to each other's scores.

Scores 2 or more points apart on any criterion go to reconciliation.

Ties broken by [criterion]. Minimum score to be considered for an award: [X].

E · DECISIONS AND APPROVAL

Federal judges make every award decision; reviewer scores advise.

Client approves criteria and weights before the stage opens.

Published to solvers: criteria and weights. Internal: anchors and scoring guide [unless agreed otherwise].

If no entry meets the minimum, the rules' no-award clause applies.

F · CALIBRATION RECORD

Date and reviewers	
Sample entries scored	
Widest spread before	
Widest spread after	
Anchors rewritten	
Client debrief items checked	

WORKFLOW [NN] OF [NN]

[Workflow name]

[One or two sentences: what this workflow produces, who it is for, and why the client cares about it.]

FEDTECH LEAD	[Role]
CLIENT COUNTERPART	[Role]
TYPICAL DURATION	[X] weeks
FINAL OUTPUT	[Deliverable]

[N] APPROVAL GATES

[N] INPUT POINTS

CLIENT INPUT

01

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT PROVIDES
[What we need from the client]

[Owner]

CLIENT APPROVAL

02

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
[The exact deliverable being approved]

[Owner] Review: [X] days

FEDTECH INTERNAL

03

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

[Owner]

FEDTECH INTERNAL

04

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

[Owner]

CLIENT APPROVAL

05

[Step name]

- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]
- [Sub-step]

CLIENT SIGNS OFF ON
[The exact deliverable being approved]

[Owner] Review: [X] days

HOW TO USE THIS TEMPLATE

Duplicate this artboard and rename it.

Copy a card of the right type for each step. Push each new card down by another 48 px to keep the diagonal.

Name what the client signs off on in every approval card. "Review the draft" isn't enough.

Update the gate and input counts, the gate sequence below, and the overview sheet.

Delete this note.

GATE SEQUENCE

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

[NN] · [Gate]
[Why this gate sits here]

References

The documents and public sources used to build this playbook, and what each one informed. Task order documents take precedence over everything here; public guidance fills the gaps.

#	SOURCE	USED FOR	LINK
	SOURCE DOCUMENTS (FEDTECH AND CLIENT, NOT PUBLIC)		
01	**NOIS3-073 FedTech proposal**	Workflows, gates, roles and the original spec sheet	Held by FedTech; not public
02	**NOIS3-085 Request for Task Order Proposal**	Prize purse distribution and the worked example; COR roles	Held by FedTech; not public
03	**CoECI PMO Expectations: NOIS3-071**	CoECI expectations and the communication rules	Held by FedTech; not public
04	**CDC/NIOSH client email on the challenge design document, Oct 2026**	Design document sections and agency clearance time	Held by FedTech; not public
05	**FedTech PM direction on CoECI, Oct 2026**	CoECI on every client communication; CoECI as a party to the task order	Held by FedTech; not public
	FEDERAL GUIDANCE AND LAW		
06	**GSA, Prize and Challenge Toolkit (2026)**	Five-phase structure; goals and measures; transition	https://www.gsa.gov/system/files/prize-challenge-toolkit-2026.pdf
07	**Challenge.gov, Toolkit phases**	Prepare, Develop, Conduct, Award, Transition	https://www.challenge.gov/archive/root/pages/toolkit/phases/
08	**Challenge.gov, Federal Agency Toolkit**	Problem definition and goal and outcome metrics	https://www.challenge.gov/assets/document-library/Challenge-Gov-Federal-Agency-Toolkit.pdf
09	**GSA, Prize competitions**	Legal framework and the Community of Practice	https://www.gsa.gov/technology/government-it-initiatives/prize-competitions
10	**15 U.S.C. 3719, America COMPETES Act prize authority (govinfo)**	Notice, eligibility, liability, IP and judges on the compliance sheet	https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/USCODE-2015-title15/html/USCODE-2015-title15-chap63-sec3719.htm
11	**15 U.S.C. 3719 (Cornell LII, current text)**	Same; current version of the statute	https://www.law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/15/3719
	RESEARCH AND PRACTICE		
12	**Deloitte, The Craft of Incentive Prize Design (2014)**	Prize design elements and pitfalls	https://www2.deloitte.com/us/en/insights/topics/social-impact/the-craft-of-incentive-prize-design.html
13	**NASA, crowdsourcing practices report (NTRS 20180007363)**	Follow up after the challenge; metrics for stakeholders	https://ntrs.nasa.gov/api/citations/20180007363/downloads/20180007363.pdf
14	**IDA, Lessons Learned: Federal Prize Competition on Inclusive Innovation Ecosystems**	Practitioner lessons on running and judging a prize	https://ida.org/research-and-publications/publications/all/l/le/lessons-learned-implementation-of-a-federal-prize-competition-on-inclusive-innovation-ecosystems
15	**Law360, Federal COVID-19 prize opportunities come with pitfalls (2020)**	No obligation to award; risks page	https://www.law360.com/articles/1282038

Public links were gathered through web searches in October 2026. Our build environment could not open the pages directly, so points were taken from search summaries; read the source before relying on a specific point.

References (continued)

The documents and public sources used to build this playbook, and what each one informed. Task order documents take precedence over everything here; public guidance fills the gaps.

#	SOURCE	USED FOR	LINK
PLAYBOOK FORMAT			
16	**U.S. Digital Service, Digital Services Playbook**	Plays with checklists and key questions	https://tech.gsa.gov/guides/digital_services_playbook/
17	**Ad Hoc, Government Digital Services Playbook (2020)**	Self-assessment checklists per play	https://adhoc.team/2020/08/18/meet-the-new-government-digital-service-playbook/
18	**18F, Delivery Partnership Playbook**	Short plays for agency partners	https://18f.gsa.gov/2015/11/19/delivery-partnership-playbook
EVALUATION BENCHMARKS (WORKFLOW 09)			
19	**XPRIZE, Carbon Removal results (2025)**	Registrations, finalists, winners	https://www.xprize.org/news/xprize-makes-history-awards-100m-prize-for-groundbreaking-carbon-removal-solutions
20	**XPRIZE Quantum Applications: semifinalists; finalist teams book**	Submissions, semifinalists, finalists, registered teams	https://thequantuminsider.com/2025/10/21/xprizes-quantum-for-real-world-impact-announces-semi-finalists/
21	**NASA, LunaRecycle Challenge finale media advisory**	Registrations, submissions, judges, Phase 1 winners	https://www.nasa.gov/news-release/nasa-invites-media-to-lunarecycle-challenge-finale-event-in-alabama/
22	**Nesta Challenge Works, Longitude Prize on AMR winner**	Teams and winner	https://www.nesta.org.uk/blog/winners-of-the-8-million-longitude-prize-on-amr-announced/
23	**NIH, 2025 NIA Start-Up Challenge and Accelerator**	Submissions, finalists, winners	https://www.nih.gov/challenges/2025-nia-start-up-challenge-and-accelerator
24	**NIBIB, 2025 DEBUT Challenge winners**	Team submissions and winners	https://www.nibib.nih.gov/news-events/newsroom/nih-announces-2025-debut-challenge-winners
25	**HHS, 2026 KidneyX EMPOWER: Living Link winners**	Submissions and winners	https://www.hhs.gov/press-room/hhs-announced-winners-of-2026-kidneyx-empower-living-link-prize-challenge.html
26	**DOE, American-Made Solar Prize Round 7**	Semifinalists, finalists, winners	https://www.energy.gov/cmei/systems/american-made-solar-prize-round-7
27	**NCATS, NIH Quantum Sensing Technology Challenge Stage 1 winners**	Stage 1 structure and winners	https://ncats.nih.gov/funding/challenges/winners/nih-quantum-sensing-technology-challenge-stage-1-winners
28	**EIC Transition 2024 results**	Applications and selections (grant call)	https://www.horizontevropa.cz/en/news/yiifnews/3040
NOIS3 BACKGROUND			
29	**NASA, NASA awards third crowdsourcing contract iteration**	NOIS3 vehicle background	https://www.nasa.gov/news-release/nasa-awards-third-crowdsourcing-contract-iteration/

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